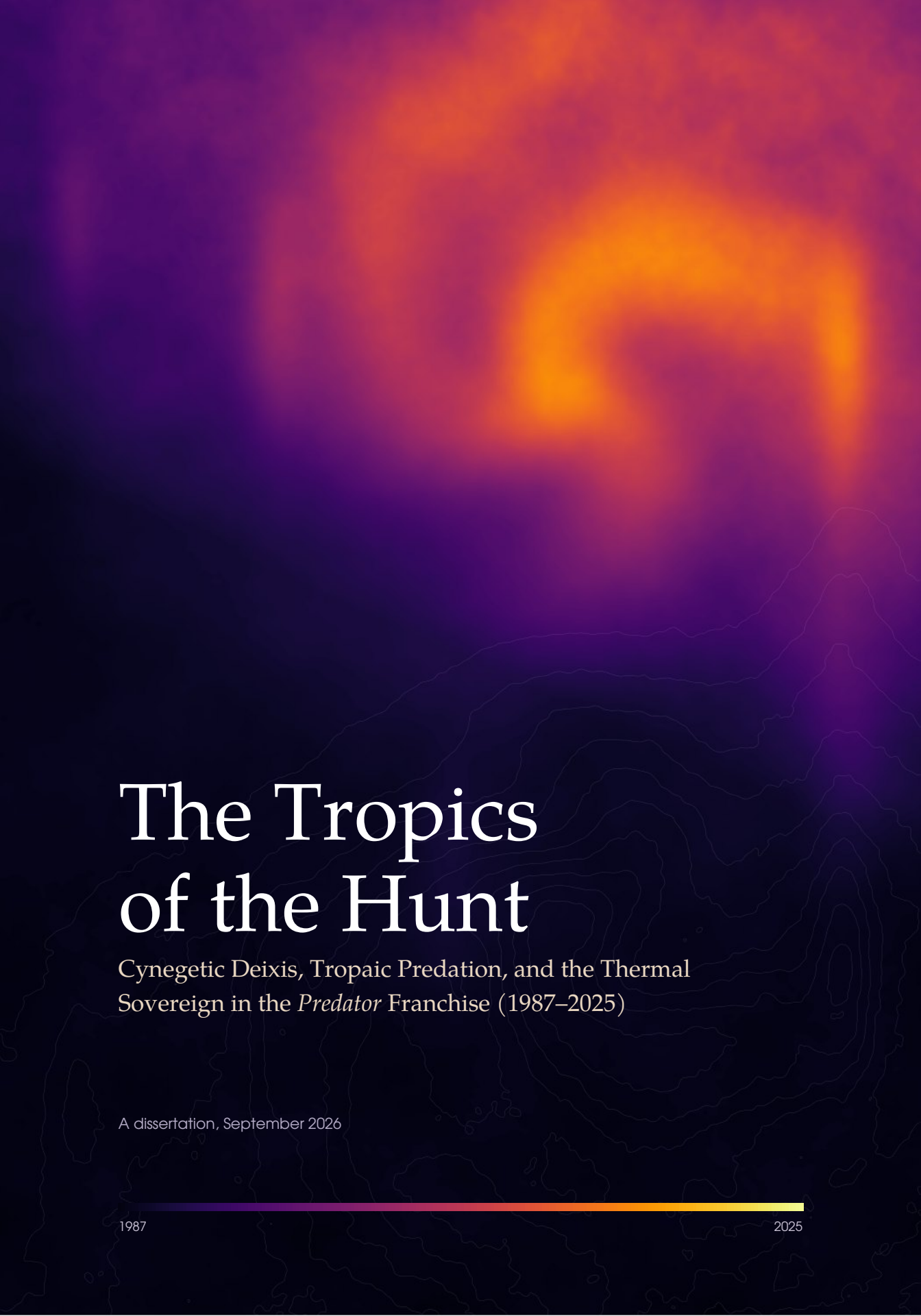


The Tropics of the Hunt

Cynegetic Deixis, Tropaic Predation, and the Thermal Sovereign in the *Predator* Franchise (1987–2025)

A dissertation, September 2026

1987 2025

Polemos pantōn men patēr esti. War is the father of all.

Heraclitus, fr. B53 (Diels–Kranz)

He was a mighty hunter before the LORD.

Genesis 10:9

"What the hell are you?"

Predator (1987), asked by Dutch and returned to him, verbatim, by the dying hunter

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the *Predator* franchise (1987–2025) constitutes a coherent modern mythic system whose governing operation is the *turn*: the semantic field of the Greek verb *trepein* (τρέπω), from which derive *tropē* (the rout, the moment an enemy turns), *tropaion* (the trophy raised at the point of that turning), *tropikos* (the solstitial turning of the sun that names the tropics), *tropos* (the figure or trope), the *apotropaic* (that which turns evil away), and, by Rudolf Clausius's coinage of 1865, *entropy* (the "transformation-content" of heat). Read through this constellation, the franchise's recurrent elements resolve into a single anthropological proposition. A hunter arrives in "the hottest years" and perceives life exclusively as heat; prey survives only by becoming thermally indistinguishable from the inanimate; bodies are flayed and hung from trees in the manner of the Greek battlefield *tropaion*; the duel is decided when the hunted turns upon the hunter; and the franchise's point of view migrates, across four decades, from the eye of the prey to the eye of the predator. I name the resulting proposition **cynegetic deixis**: in the world of the franchise, personhood is neither a species property nor a rational endowment but a *position within the predatory relation*, conferred upon whoever can return the hunter's gaze, bleed and make bleed, and turn.

The argument proceeds through five registers. *Genealogically*, it reconstructs the franchise's sources in Richard Connell's "The Most Dangerous Game" (1924), the classical cynegetic literature (Xenophon's *Cynegeticus*, Plato's *Laws* VII), José Ortega y Gasset's *Meditations on Hunting* (1942), and the twentieth-century paleoanthropological dispute between "Man the Hunter" (Dart, Ardrey, Washburn and Lancaster) and "Man the Hunted" (Brain, Hart and Sussman, Ehrenreich, Plumwood). *Phenomenologically*, it theorizes the Predator's infrared vision as a **thermal gaze** that reduces beings to what I call *bare heat*, drawing on Uexküll, Lacan, Foucault, Virilio, and Roger Caillois's theory of mimicry. *Ethically*, it reads the Yautja code through Huizinga, Nietzsche, Hegel and Kojève, Carl Schmitt's "bracketing" of war, and Michael Walzer's war convention, arguing that the Predator's mercy is a form of disqualification rather than compassion. *Materially*, it develops a theory of **tropaic predation**, predation for display rather than ingestion, via Meuli and Burkert, Kristeva, Bataille, and the anthropology of "dark trophies." *Politically*, it identifies a recurrent **apparatus of capture** (intelligence agency, federal task force, colonial trader, corporation) that seeks to convert the sovereign

expenditure of the hunt into resource, using Deleuze and Guattari, Heidegger, Agamben, and E. P. Thompson.

Comparative chapters situate the Predator among the Wild Hunt, Tezcatlipoca's smoking mirror, Perseus and the Gorgon, Actaeon, Gilgamesh, Beowulf, and the *einherjar* of Valhalla, and within the modern bestiary of horror (Carroll, Wood, Girard, Creed, Clover, Lovecraft). A diachronic reading then demonstrates that the franchise has evolved dialectically: from predation as *disqualification* (1987–1990), through predation *captured* by state and capital (2004–2018), to predation as the generative ground of *kinship* (2022–2025). This trajectory converges, unexpectedly, on what Amazonian ethnology terms *familiarizing predation* (Fausto; Viveiros de Castro; Kohn). The dissertation concludes that the Predator is the Anthropocene's demon of the hottest years: a **thermotropic sovereign** whose return dramatizes humanity's oldest and most thoroughly repressed knowledge, that it was, and may again become, prey.



Introduction

The Question Returned

1. The Problem
2. Corpus and Periodization
3. Method: Cynegetic Hermeneutics
4. The Thesis in Brief
5. Plan of the Work

1 The Problem

The founding utterance of the *Predator* franchise is a question that changes its referent in the act of being repeated. At the climax of John McTiernan's *Predator* (1987), Major Alan "Dutch" Schaefer stands over the shattered body of the creature that has flayed his unit and asks, "What the hell are you?" The dying hunter, which has spent the film recording and replaying human voices, returns the sentence unchanged. In Dutch's mouth the second-person pronoun points at the alien; in the alien's it points at Dutch. The question is therefore not taxonomic but *deictic*: like "I," "here," and "now," its reference is fixed only by the position of the speaker. Everything this dissertation argues is latent in that exchange. The franchise does not ask what the human *is* as a natural kind; it asks what the human becomes when it occupies the grammatical and ontological position of the one who is hunted, and what the hunter becomes when it is made, at last, to answer for itself.

Popular criticism has treated the franchise unevenly. Its sibling, the *Alien* cycle, has been read as feminist psychoanalytic allegory (Creed), as philosophy conducted in the medium of film (Mulhall), and as a critique of corporate biopower; the *Predator* films have more often been filed under the Reagan-era action spectacle and read through three serviceable allegories: Vietnam re-fought in a Central American jungle, the "hard body" of Reaganite masculinity (Jeffords) brought to crisis, and colonial violence inverted upon the colonizer. Each allegory is correct and each is partial. None accounts for the franchise's most singular structural feature: a monster whose relation to the human is neither *alimentary* (the vampire, the zombie, the shark), nor *reproductive* (the Xenomorph), nor *possessive* (the demon), nor *annihilative* (the kaiju), but **commemorative**. The Predator does not eat its prey. It honors it, flays it, hangs it, keeps its skull. Its horror is the horror of being memorialized by one's killer.

2 Corpus and Periodization

The primary corpus comprises nine feature films released between 1987 and 2025, read here as a single mythic system in Claude Lévi-Strauss's sense: a myth is the totality of its variants, and no version is privileged as the "original" against which the others are deviations. The phase designations in the final column anticipate the argument of Chapter Eight.

Year	Title	Direction	Writing	Setting	Phase
2025	*Predator: Badlands*	Dan Trachtenberg	Patrick Aison (story with Trachtenberg)	Genna; Yautja Prime	III: Kinship
2025	*Predator: Killer of Killers*	Dan Trachtenberg, Josh Wassung	Micho Robert Rutare	Viking-age Scandinavia; feudal Japan; Second World War; a Yautja arena	III: Kinship
2022	*Prey*	Dan Trachtenberg	Patrick Aison (story with Trachtenberg)	Comanche Nation, Northern Great Plains, 1719	III: Kinship
2018	*The Predator*	Shane Black	Fred Dekker, Shane Black	Contemporary United States	II: Capture
2010	*Predators*	Nimród Antal	Alex Litvak, Michael Finch	An extraterrestrial game preserve	II: Capture
2007	*Aliens vs. Predator: Requiem*	Colin and Greg Strause	Shane Salerno	Gunnison, Colorado	II: Capture
2004	*AVP: Alien vs. Predator*	Paul W. S. Anderson	Anderson (story with Dan O'Bannon, Ronald Shusett)	Bouvetøya, Antarctica	II: Capture
1990	*Predator 2*	Stephen Hopkins	Jim Thomas, John Thomas	Los Angeles, 1997	I: Disqualification
1987	*Predator*	John McTiernan	Jim Thomas, John Thomas	"Val Verde," a Central American jungle	I: Disqualification

A secondary, apocryphal corpus is consulted for vocabulary but not treated as canonical: the Dark Horse comics (from 1989), Steve and Stephani Perry's novel *Aliens vs. Predator: Prey* (1994), which coined the species name *Yautja*, and the video games, notably Rebellion's *Aliens versus Predator* (1999), with its three species-specific campaigns, and Illfonic's *Predator: Hunting Grounds* (2020), whose asymmetrical design lets one player occupy the hunter's position against four. The corpus is closed at *Badlands* (November 2025). As of this writing no further installment has been released, and in February 2026 Trachtenberg described the franchise's next steps as still being worked out[17].

3 Method: Cynegetic Hermeneutics

The method is named for the classical genre of hunting treatises, the *cynegetica* (Greek *kynēgetikos*, from *kyōn*, "dog," and *hēgeisthai*, "to lead"), and it operates on five levels at once. It is *philological*, attending to the semantic field of *trepein* and to the etymological sediment of the franchise's key terms (*trophy*, *tropics*, *forest*, *entropy*). It is *structural-mythological*, isolating recurrent mythemes and tracking their transformations across variants. It is *philosophical*, treating the films, after Mulhall, not as illustrations of theses formulated elsewhere but as sites where thinking occurs. It is *anthropological*, reading the franchise against the ethnography of hunting peoples, above all the Amerindian theory of predation reconstructed by Eduardo Viveiros de Castro, Carlos Fausto, and Eduardo Kohn. And it is *political*, attending to the institutions (agencies, corporations, colonial traders) that the films repeatedly place between hunter and hunted.

Ten mythemes recur across the corpus and organize the analysis: (1) the hunter's arrival in heat; (2) the invisible observer; (3) the flayed body hung as *tropaion*; (4) the disqualification of the unarmed; (5) the betrayal of the hunted by their own sovereign; (6) the subtraction of the prey's signature (mud, flower, suit); (7) the unmasking and the face-to-face; (8) the hunter's mimicry of its victims' voices; (9) the self-destruct, or apotropaic expenditure; and (10) the gift of recognition (pistol, spear, mark).

4 The Thesis in Brief

The dissertation advances five propositions, which converge on a sixth. *Ontologically*, the franchise runs what Giorgio Agamben calls the "anthropological machine" in reverse: instead of producing the human by excluding the animal, it collapses the human into the animal under an alien gaze and then re-produces personhood through the hunt itself. *Perceptually*, the Predator's infrared sensorium constitutes a **thermal gaze** that reduces every being to *bare heat*, a thermographic analogue of Agamben's bare life. *Ethically*, the Yautja code is a regime of bracketed, agonal violence whose restraint toward the unarmed is not compassion but disqualification; its proper object is what I term the *justa praeda*, the lawful prey, modeled on Schmitt's *justus hostis*. *Materially*, the franchise invents **tropaic predation**, killing for display rather than ingestion, whose apotheosis is the self-destruct as an act of sovereign expenditure. *Politically*, the true antagonist of every installment is an **apparatus of capture** that seeks to convert the hunt into resource, against which the protagonists' counter-hunt, conducted through cunning (*mētis*) rather than force (*biē*), constitutes the franchise's ethical horizon.

The sixth proposition, the dissertation's original contribution, is **cynegetic deixis**: personhood in the franchise is a *position* within the predatory relation, conferred upon whoever can return the hunter's gaze, bleed and make bleed, and turn. Across four decades the franchise rotates that position from the prey's eye to the predator's, and in doing so moves from predation as disqualification, through predation as capture, to predation as the ground of kinship.

5 Plan of the Work

Chapter One reconstructs the franchise's genealogy: Connell, the classical *cynegetica*, Ortega y Gasset, the paleoanthropology of predation, and the production context of 1986–1990. Chapter Two theorizes the thermal gaze. Chapter Three anatomizes the code. Chapter Four develops the theory of tropaic predation. Chapter Five identifies the apparatus of capture. Chapters Six and Seven situate the Predator within world mythology and the modern bestiary of horror. Chapter Eight reads the corpus diachronically as a dialectic. Chapter Nine consolidates the thesis of cynegetic deixis, organized by the four turns of *trepein*, and confronts its objections. The Conclusion asks what remains of the human after the hunt.



Chapter One

Genealogies of the Hunt

1.1 From Rocky to Zaroff: The Agon Escalated
1.2 The Classical Cynegetica: Paideia, Legislation, Natural Slavery
1.3 Ortega y Gasset: The Ethics of Self-Limitation
1.4 Man the Hunter, Man the Hunted
1.5 The Production Context, 1986–1990

1.1 From *Rocky* to Zaroff: The Agon Escalated

According to widely repeated production lore, Jim and John Thomas conceived the screenplay that became *Predator* (working title *Hunter*) in response to an industry joke: after *Rocky IV* (1985) had pitted its boxer against the Soviet Union, the only adversary left was an extraterrestrial. The anecdote is more than trivia. It records the franchise's originating logic as an *escalation of the agon*. The Cold War had already reduced geopolitics to the ring; the next step was to subtract the last commonality between combatants, membership in a single species, and to ask what remains of contest, honor, and recognition when the adversary is absolutely other.

The narrative template that the Thomas brothers inherited, whether by direct influence or generic sedimentation, is Richard Connell's "The Most Dangerous Game" (*Collier's*, 19 January 1924). Connell's General Zaroff, a Cossack aristocrat bored by animals that cannot reason, hunts shipwrecked sailors on Ship-Trap Island under explicit rules: a head start, provisions, a knife, and freedom for any quarry that survives three days. Rainsford, the big-game hunter who becomes prey, opens the story by declaring that "the world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees," and closes it having learned what the second class knows. His survival depends on traps borrowed from colonial ethnography (a Malay man-catcher, a Burmese tiger pit, a Ugandan knife trap). Every element migrates into the franchise. The aristocratic hunter becomes an alien sovereign; the island becomes the jungle, the city, the game planet; the rules become the code; the colonial traps become Dutch's improvised deadfalls, stakes, and bow. Dutch is, in Lévi-Strauss's terms, a *bricoleur* who "makes do" with what is at hand, set against an *engineer* whose instruments are purpose-built.

One transformation, however, is decisive. Zaroff is a man hunting men, and therefore a criminal; his hunt is horrifying because it violates a species-wide prohibition. The Predator belongs to another species, and its hunt is therefore not a crime but a *practice*, as legitimate within its own order as Rainsford's jaguar hunts were within his. The franchise thus relocates the horror of Connell's story. It no longer resides in the hunter's transgression but in the prey's *demotion*: the discovery that the human, considered from outside the species, is game. The moral scandal shifts from "this man is a monster" to "we are animals," which is the scandal Darwin introduced and that the hunting cultures of modernity had laboured to forget.

Two further ancestors deserve naming. Walter Hill's *Southern Comfort* (1981), in which a National Guard unit is hunted through the Louisiana bayou by locals

it has wronged, already fused the Vietnam allegory with the man-hunt plot. Michael Cimino's *The Deer Hunter* (1978) established, through Michael Vronsky's creed of the single clean shot and his eventual refusal to kill the stag, that the ethics of the hunt could serve American cinema as a displaced language for the ethics of war. *Predator* inherits both: a unit hunted by an environment it has violated, and a hunter whose code is legible only to another hunter.

1.2 The Classical *Cynegetica*: Paideia, Legislation, Natural Slavery

The Western tradition did not merely practice hunting; it legislated and theorized it, and in doing so it produced the concepts the franchise would later turn against their authors. Xenophon's *Cynegeticus* presents the hunt as *paideia*, an education in endurance, vigilance, and courage that makes men fit for war and citizenship, and it traces the art's mythic lineage to the centaur Chiron, tutor of Achilles and Theseus. The Yautja rite of passage that *AVP* (2004) makes explicit, and that *Badlands* (2025) places at the center of its narrative, is cynegetic paideia in Xenophon's sense: the hunt makes the warrior.

Plato's *Laws* (VII, 822d–824a) goes further and legislates the hunt's forms. The Athenian Stranger praises only the hunting of land animals by day, with horses, dogs, and one's own body, in which the hunter conquers by running, striking, and throwing; he condemns night-hunting, nets, and traps as idle techniques that do not train the soul, and he calls the approved practitioners "sacred hunters." The Yautja code satisfies Plato's criterion at its climax, when the hunter abandons its plasma caster and mask to risk its own body, and violates it throughout, in its nets, its invisibility, its nocturnal ambushes. The franchise's Predator is thus a hybrid of Plato's sacred hunter and his despised trapper, and its internal oscillation between the two is the drama of the code. Plato's *Sophist* (218e–223b), meanwhile, classifies the hunting of "tame animals," by which it means human beings, and divides it into violent forms (war, piracy, tyranny) and persuasive ones (law, oratory, love, sophistry). The franchise inhabits the first branch of that taxonomy with an unsettling literalism.

The darkest node in this genealogy is Aristotle. In *Politics* I.8 (1256b), war is described as a natural art of acquisition that includes hunting, to be practiced "against wild beasts, and against men who, though intended by nature to be governed, will not submit," since such war is "naturally just." This sentence, revived by Juan Ginés de Sepúlveda against Bartolomé de las Casas at Valladolid (1550–51), underwrites what Grégoire Chamayou's *Manhunts: A Philosophical History* (2010) reconstructs as a continuous Western practice: the

hunting of slaves, of the colonized, of fugitives, of the poor, of migrants. The franchise's inversion is exact. To the Yautja, humanity occupies precisely Aristotle's category: beings that, from the hunter's standpoint, exist to be pursued. The Western theory of the just manhunt returns from the sky.

Chamayou's later *Drone Theory* (2013) completes the genealogy in a register the franchise could not have anticipated in 1987. The United States Air Force's MQ-1 Predator, operational from 1995 and armed from 2001, became the emblematic instrument of targeted killing; its successor, the MQ-9 Reaper, was classed as a "hunter-killer." Chamayou argues that drone warfare abolishes the reciprocity that made combat a duel and converts war into a manhunt, executed in the so-called "signature strike" against persons identified only by behavioral and thermal patterns. Whatever the provenance of its name, the real Predator violates every precept of the fictional one: it risks nothing, shows no face, spares no one for being unarmed, and kills by signature alone. Chapter Five develops the irony that the franchise's monster is more scrupulous than the weapon that borrowed its name.

1.3 Ortega y Gasset: The Ethics of Self-Limitation

The most important modern philosophy of the hunt, and the one that most precisely anticipates the Yautja code, is José Ortega y Gasset's *Meditations on Hunting*, written in 1942 as a prologue to the Conde de Yebes's *Veinte años de caza mayor*. Ortega makes three claims. First, the hunt is a deliberate return to an earlier stratum of human existence, a "vacation" from history in which the hunter re-enters the Paleolithic relation between predator and prey. Second, that relation demands a distinctive mode of consciousness, a "universal attention" in which the hunter is the alert man par excellence. Third, and decisively, the hunt is constituted by a *limit on the hunter's superiority*. If the hunter's technical advantage becomes absolute, hunting degenerates into mere killing; its ethics therefore require that the hunter renounce part of his power so that the animal retains its chance. The formula for which the book is remembered inverts the instrumental relation between means and end: one does not hunt in order to kill; one kills in order to have hunted.

The Predator is Ortega's hunter transposed to a civilization whose technology would otherwise make the hunt meaningless. A species capable of interstellar flight, optical invisibility, and plasma weaponry could exterminate a human patrol from orbit. It chooses instead to descend, to stalk, to limit itself, and finally to strip away its advantages in order to meet its quarry body to body.

Ortega's ethic explains this behaviour more economically than any appeal to alien psychology: technical superiority is precisely what the hunter must *spend down* in order for the hunt to exist. Ortega's aristocratic presuppositions (the *caza mayor* of the Spanish nobility) also migrate into the franchise, which consistently codes the Yautja as a warrior caste and their hunting grounds as a sovereign preserve, a point developed in Chapter Five.

Matt Cartmill's *A View to a Death in the Morning* (1993) supplies the necessary counterweight. Cartmill shows that the "hunting hypothesis" of human origins was a modern myth with a moral charge, and that its antithesis, crystallized in Felix Salten's *Bambi* (1923) and Disney's adaptation (1942), cast the human hunter as an invisible, near-divine killer whom the forest's inhabitants know only by its report. The *Predator* franchise is, among other things, *Bambi* told from the deer's side with the deer replaced by Green Berets: an unseen hunter is in the forest, and the forest's creatures learn of it only by their dead.

1.4 Man the Hunter, Man the Hunted

The franchise intervenes, without citing it, in the central paleoanthropological controversy of the twentieth century. Raymond Dart's "The Predatory Transition from Ape to Man" (1953) proposed that the australopithecines were carnivorous killers whose bone weapons inaugurated human history; Robert Ardrey's *African Genesis* (1961) popularized the "killer ape," and the Dart–Ardrey thesis shaped the bone-weapon prologue of Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968). The 1966 "Man the Hunter" symposium, published in 1968 under that title (ed. Lee and DeVore), gave the idea its most influential formulation in Washburn and Lancaster's claim that hunting was the master pattern that shaped human intellect, emotion, and sociality.

The counter-tradition began in the cave of Swartkrans. C. K. Brain's taphonomic analyses, synthesized in *The Hunters or the Hunted?* (1981), showed that many of the bone accumulations Dart had read as the debris of hominin killers were the remains of hominins *killed*, above all by leopards. The juvenile skull SK 54 bears two punctures matching a leopard's lower canines. Lee Berger and Ron Clarke later argued (1995) that the Taung Child, the founding specimen of *Australopithecus*, was killed by a large raptor. Donna Hart and Robert W. Sussman's *Man the Hunted* (2005) generalized the point: primate and early hominin sociality, vigilance, and cooperation are best understood as anti-predator adaptations. Lynne Isbell's snake-detection theory (2009) traced the acuity of primate vision itself to millions of years of selection by serpents,

which, notably, include the pit vipers and pythons that hunt by infrared.

Barbara Ehrenreich's *Blood Rites* (1997) converted this evidence into a theory of the passions. The primal emotional template of war, she argues, derives not from humanity's triumph as hunter but from its long apprenticeship as prey: the terror, the collective defense, the sacralization of the predator, and the later ritual reenactment of predation in sacrifice. Val Plumwood's "Being Prey," her account of surviving a saltwater crocodile's death-rolls in Kakadu in 1985, supplies the phenomenology: the shock of discovering oneself as *edible*, and the realization that Western dualism had exempted the human from the food chain by fiat. David Quammen's *Monster of God* (2003) adds the theological coda: the great predators were humanity's living reminders of its finitude, and their extinction removes a dimension of human self-knowledge.

Against this background the franchise's founding gesture becomes legible. *Predator* takes the most perfect avatar of "Man the Hunter" that Reaganite culture could produce, a special-operations unit of near-superhuman bodies armed with a rotary cannon, and returns it to the cave of Swartkrans. The film is a *paleo-anamnesis*, an unforgetting: it restores to consciousness the prey-memory that the hunting hypothesis had overwritten.

1.5 The Production Context, 1986–1990

Predator was shot in 1986 in the Mexican jungles near Puerto Vallarta and Palenque and released on 12 June 1987, in the middle of the televised Iran–Contra hearings (May–August 1987). Its plot, a rescue mission in the fictional Central American republic of Val Verde that conceals a CIA intelligence operation, ventriloquizes the covert interventions of the period in Nicaragua, El Salvador, Honduras, and Guatemala, down to the Soviet advisers in the guerrilla camp. Dillon's confession that he regarded Dutch's men as an "expendable asset" is the film's political hinge. The muscular spectacle that Susan Jeffords's *Hard Bodies* (1994) and Yvonne Tasker's *Spectacular Bodies* (1993) identified as the signature of Reagan-era cinema is here mobilized only to be dismantled. The scene in which the unit empties its weapons, the rotary cannon "Old Painless" included, into an empty jungle stages the exhaustion of what David Nye calls the American technological sublime. That two members of the cast (Schwarzenegger and Jesse Ventura) later became state governors is an ironic footnote on the political charge of these bodies.

The creature itself is a palimpsest. An abandoned first design was replaced by Stan Winston's studio, with the arthropod mandibles reportedly suggested by

James Cameron, fresh from *Aliens* (1986), a film that had already stranded an elite unit in an alien ecology. The optical cloak was realized by R/Greenberg Associates; Alan Silvestri's percussive score fused the military march with the ritual drum. The performer inside the suit, Kevin Peter Hall, played the gentle Sasquatch of *Harry and the Hendersons* in the same month, June 1987: the medieval Wild Man's two faces, domesticated and sovereign, worn by a single body.

The auteurial afterlives confirm the genealogy. Stephen Hopkins, who directed *Predator* 2 (1990) after *A Nightmare on Elm Street 5*, went on to make *The Ghost and the Darkness* (1996), a dramatization of the Tsavo man-eaters of 1898, whose skins are now trophies in Chicago's Field Museum. McTiernan's *The 13th Warrior* (1999), adapted from Michael Crichton's *Beowulf* pastiche *Eaters of the Dead* (1976), returned to the scenario of a warrior band besieged by a nocturnal, trophy-taking enemy. Shane Black, who played Hawkins, the first of Dutch's men to die in 1987, returned in 2018 to direct *The Predator*. The franchise's first trophy came back as its author.

II

Chapter Two

The Thermal Gaze

2.1 The Logistics of Perception
2.2 Umwelt and the Tick: A Captivated Sovereign
2.3 Bare Heat
2.4 The Jungle That Looks Back
2.5 Mimicry and Legendary Psychasthenia: Cloak and Mud
2.6 Entropy and the Outis Gambit

2.1 The Logistics of Perception

The most consequential formal invention of *Predator* is not its creature but its point of view. Intercut with the commandos' daylight jungle are shots in false-colour thermography: bodies blaze in reds and yellows against a cold blue ground, foliage dissolves into thermal noise, and a man becomes a luminous silhouette indistinguishable in kind from a boar. The spectator is not merely shown the alien; the spectator is *installed* in its perceptual world, and the editing alternates between two incommensurable worlds that share a single geography.

Paul Virilio's *War and Cinema: The Logistics of Perception* (1984) supplies the genealogy of this device. For Virilio the history of battle is primarily the history of changing fields of perception; the weapon and the eye converge, and the decisive advantage belongs to whoever sees without being seen. Infrared sensing was the perceptual signature of the American war in Southeast Asia: the electronic battlefield of Operation Igloo White and the infrared sensors of night-flying gunships rendered Vietnamese bodies as heat on a screen. By 1987 this scopic regime, the term is Martin Jay's after Christian Metz, was the prosthetic eye of American dominance, and four years later it would become the televised aesthetic of the Gulf War. *Predator* turns that eye around. The thermal gaze the film assigns to the alien is the American military's own way of seeing, alienated and returned to American soldiers. The jungle's new sovereign sees as the gunship saw.

2.2 Umwelt and the Tick: A Captivated Sovereign

Jakob von Uexküll's *A Foray into the Worlds of Animals and Humans* (1934) opens with the tick. Blind and deaf, the tick inhabits an *Umwelt* constituted by three carriers of significance: the butyric acid of mammalian sweat, the warmth of mammalian blood, and the texture of hair and skin. It can wait, Uexküll reports, for years in suspended animation until warmth announces its prey. The Predator's sensorium is, in its primary register, a tick's: it knows its quarry first and foremost as warmth. The paradox is constitutive. The most technologically advanced being in the franchise perceives the world through the oldest parasitic schema, the one shared by ticks, mosquitoes, vampire bats, and the pit vipers that Isbell credits with sharpening primate vision. Primates evolved to see snakes; the franchise imagines the snake that sees primates.

Martin Heidegger's lecture course of 1929–30, *The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics*, ranked beings by their relation to world: the stone is worldless, the animal "poor in world" (*weltarm*), the human "world-forming" (*weltbildend*).

The animal, for Heidegger, is "captivated" (*benommen*) by the disinhibitors that release its behaviour, unable to apprehend beings *as* beings. Giorgio Agamben's *The Open: Man and Animal* (2002) reads Uexküll's tick and Heidegger's captivation together as the twin hinges of what he calls the anthropological machine, the apparatus by which Western thought produces the human through the exclusion of the animal within it. The Predator jams that machine. It is world-forming in Heidegger's sense, a builder of ships, weapons, and trophy halls, and captivated in Uexküll's, drawn to heat as the tick is drawn to warmth. It is a **captivated sovereign**, and its existence refutes the hierarchy on which the distinction between human and animal had been staked.

Eduardo Viveiros de Castro's account of Amerindian perspectivism specifies what the franchise's montage enacts. In the cosmologies he reconstructs, all beings see themselves as persons possessing culture; what differs is the body, and with it the world each body discloses. Jaguars see blood as manioc beer; vultures see maggots as grilled fish; predators see humans as game. Against modern *multiculturalism*, one nature and many cultures, he names this *multinaturalism*: one culture, many natures. The cut between the commandos' jungle and the Predator's thermogram is a multinaturalist cut. The two parties share a culture, a warrior ethos of tracking, ambush, honor, and the kill, and inhabit two natures. The asymmetry that drives the narrative is that the hunter can change natures at will (*Predator 2* shows it cycling through spectral modes until Keyes's thermally shielded team becomes visible) while the prey, until the franchise's late phase, cannot.

2.3 Bare Heat

The thermal gaze sees nothing of biography, language, rank, nation, or creed. It registers only metabolism, the local thermodynamic disequilibrium that Erwin Schrödinger, in *What Is Life?* (1944), identified with the organism's capacity to feed on "negative entropy." I call the object of this gaze **bare heat**. The term is constructed on Agamben's *bare life* (*nuda vita*), the *zoē* stripped of the *bios* of political existence, and it designates the thermographic hypostasis of that condition: life reduced to its signature. Bare heat is a radically egalitarian category and a radically degrading one. In the Predator's eyes the guerrilla, the Green Beret, and the boar that Dutch's men gun down in the night are equal, because equally warm.

Prey (2022) dramatizes the gaze's indifference to species by staging an ascent. Its Predator kills a snake, then a wolf, then a bear, then human beings, climbing

what Arthur Lovejoy called the Great Chain of Being one heat signature at a time in search of the most dangerous game. The ascent is a parody of the scala naturae: the hierarchy is preserved, but the criterion of rank is no longer reason or soul. It is dangerousness, a point Chapter Three develops into a theory of the code.

The concept of bare heat has acquired a historical referent the franchise could not have intended. Contemporary targeting doctrine speaks of "signatures" and "patterns of life"; the signature strike, as Chamayou documents, kills persons whose identities are unknown on the basis of their observed behavioural and thermal profiles. Border surveillance, too, operates through thermal imaging, and during the COVID-19 pandemic entire populations passed through fever-screening checkpoints that registered nothing but surface temperature. The franchise's thermal gaze was a prophecy of what might be called *thermopolitics*: the government of populations through their heat.

2.4 The Jungle That Looks Back

In Seminar XI (1964), Jacques Lacan recounts an anecdote from his youth. On a fishing boat off Brittany, a fisherman named Petit-Jean pointed to a sardine can glittering on the waves and said: you see that can? Well, it doesn't see you. Lacan found the joke unfunny, because the can *was* looking at him, in the sense that the light point situated him, a young intellectual out of place among working men, as a stain in the picture. The episode grounds his distinction between the eye, which belongs to the subject, and the gaze, which belongs to the field of the Other and photographs the subject from outside. *Predator* is the sardine can made into a creature. Dutch's men have eyes; the jungle has the gaze. Billy, the unit's tracker, articulates the Lacanian intuition before any evidence confirms it: something is out there, and it is not a man.

Michel Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) opens with the public dismemberment of Damiens in 1757 and proceeds to Bentham's Panopticon, narrating the historical passage from sovereign power, which displays its force on the condemned body, to disciplinary power, which works through invisible, continuous observation. The Predator collapses the two regimes Foucault separated. It observes invisibly, like Bentham's inspector, and it displays the flayed body, like the sovereign's scaffold. It does not, however, discipline. The panoptic gaze in Foucault induces the observed to police themselves; the Predator's gaze dissolves discipline. Under its pressure Dutch's unit disintegrates into grief (Mac), bravado (Blain), and sacrificial resignation

(Billy). The Predator is a pre-modern sovereign equipped with post-modern optics.

The effect on the spectator is what Freud's essay "The Uncanny" (1919) theorizes as the return of the familiar in estranged form. The cloaked hunter is a ripple in a jungle that looks exactly like a jungle; its voice is the voice of the dead, replayed ("over here," "turn around," a dead man's laughter). Freud locates the uncanny in the double, the automaton, the severed limb, and the threat to the eyes, the last exemplified by Hoffmann's Sandman. Every one of these figures recurs in the franchise. Above all, Freud's claim that the uncanny is the return of something long repressed finds its referent in the prey-memory reconstructed in Chapter One: what returns in the shimmer is the oldest situation of the species.

It is significant that Billy, coded by the 1987 film as a Native American tracker, is the first to perceive the gaze and the first to answer it in kind. He discards his rifle on a log bridge, cuts his own chest with his blade, and waits for the hunter with a knife. The scene trades on the trope of the mystically attuned native, and that trope deserves the criticism it has received. It also anticipates, by thirty-five years, the franchise's eventual relocation of hunting knowledge into an Indigenous protagonist in *Prey*.

2.5 Mimicry and Legendary Psychasthenia: Cloak and Mud

Roger Caillois's "Mimicry and Legendary Psychasthenia," published in *Minotaure* in 1935 and later cited by Lacan, argues that mimicry in insects is not primarily a defensive adaptation, since mimetic species are eaten as often as others. It is rather a "temptation by space," a depersonalization in which the organism ceases to be the origin of its own coordinates and becomes merely similar to its surroundings. Caillois compares this condition to schizophrenic experiences of being devoured by space, and he posits, alongside the instinct of self-preservation, an instinct of renunciation that orients the organism toward a reduced, quasi-inanimate mode of existence.

The franchise contains two mimicries, symmetrical and opposed. The Predator's cloak is *optical* mimicry: light bends around the body, and the hunter becomes the jungle. Dutch's mud is *thermal* mimicry: after his plunge from the waterfall he discovers by accident that the creature cannot see him, and he coats himself to become, in the infrared, a riverbank. In both cases mastery is achieved through self-dissolution into space. The final duel is a contest of psychasthenias, in which the hunter disappears into the visible and the hunted into the warm. Caillois's *Man, Play and Games* (1958) later made mimicry one of four irreducible

categories of play, beside *agôn* (contest), *alea* (chance), and *ilinx* (vertigo). The Yautja hunt fuses *agôn* and *mimicry*, the masked contest, a combination that Caillois associated with the threshold between "Dionysian" societies of mask and trance and "rational" societies of competition and rule. The Yautja inhabit that threshold permanently.

2.6 Entropy and the Outis Gambit

In 1865 Rudolf Clausius named the quantity measuring the dissipation of heat *entropy*, from the Greek *tropē*, "transformation." The word belongs to the same family as *trophy* and *tropics*, and its presence in the franchise is not accidental at the level of structure. Life, in Schrödinger's account, is a local resistance to entropy; the thermal gaze perceives precisely that resistance. To vanish from it, the prey must simulate thermal equilibrium, which is to say it must simulate death. Dutch's mud is a death mask in the strictest sense: in the infrared he becomes indistinguishable from the inorganic. Naru's orange flower (*totsiyaa*), a Comanche medicinal herb that lowers body temperature, drives her physiology toward the ambient, toward the thermal condition of a corpse. Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) posited a drive to return to the inorganic that coexists with the drives of self-preservation; the franchise discovers a homeopathy of death in which the only way to survive the hunter is to approach, voluntarily and provisionally, the state toward which the death drive tends.

The hunter's own death completes the thermodynamic allegory. Defeated, the Predator of 1987 arms a device in its gauntlet and dies laughing as it converts itself into a fireball whose mushroom cloud invokes the Cold War's supreme entropic weapon. The being that perceives life as heat leaves the world as pure heat. Heraclitus, who called the cosmos an ever-living fire kindled and extinguished in measures (fr. B30), supplies the appropriate cosmology: the hunter returns to the element through which it saw.

The prey's countermeasure has a Homeric name. In *Odyssey* 9, Odysseus tells the Cyclops his name is *Outis*, "Nobody." When the blinded Polyphemus cries that Nobody is killing him, his neighbours answer that if no one (*mē tis*) is harming him, he must be ill, and Odysseus laughs that his name and his cunning (*mētis*) had deceived them. The pun is canonical, and Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant's *Cunning Intelligence in Greek Culture and Society* (1974) reconstructs the field it names: *mētis* is the intelligence of hunters, fishermen, and trappers, of the fox and the octopus, of the net and the snare; it is polymorphic,

oblique, and it defeats force (*biē*) by reversal, turning the opponent's strength against him. The Cyclops's single eye is the hunter's mask. Dutch, by becoming thermally nobody, performs what I call the **Outis gambit**: the subtraction of one's own signature from the field of the sovereign gaze.

The gambit's complement is the **mētic reversal**. Dutch's counterweight trap converts the hunter's mass into the instrument of its ruin; Harrigan kills with the Predator's own disc; Naru, wearing the creature's captured mask, lays its targeting laser on its own head so that its projectile turns back upon it. Each victory is literally a *tropē*, a turn, and each is achieved by a body that has first made itself invisible. Disappear, then turn: these are the two moves of the counter-hunt, and they recur in every installment of the franchise.

III

Chapter Three

The Code

3.1 The Magic Circle and the Most Dangerous Man
3.2 Disqualification: The Mercy That Is Contempt
3.3 The Struggle for Pure Prestige
3.4 Bracketing Beyond the Line
3.5 Dangerous Men: The Thermographic War Convention
3.6 If It Bleeds: Equality, Recognition, and the Agonal Face
3.7 The Gift of the Enemy
3.8 The Code Turned Inward

The Yautja code is not a morality of restraint but a grammar of eligibility. It answers a single question, *who may be hunted?*, and its apparent mercies are judgments of unworthiness. This chapter reconstructs that grammar from five sources (Huizinga's theory of play, Nietzsche's aristocratic agonism, the Hegelian and Kojèvean struggle for recognition, Carl Schmitt's bracketing of war, and Michael Walzer's war convention) and follows it to the point at which it turns inward, where the criterion that spares the unarmed human condemns the weak Yautja.

3.1 The Magic Circle and the Most Dangerous Man

The code is legible in the screenplay's earliest form. According to accounts of its development, the Thomas brothers' *Hunter* (1984) began as a story about "what it is to be hunted," in which alien hunters of several species pursued various quarry; it was streamlined into a single hunter in pursuit of the most dangerous species and, within that species, the "most dangerous man," the combat soldier[1]. The formula transposes Connell's title into a selection criterion, and the whole code is already contained in it. The quarry is defined not by species, edibility, or guilt but by *danger*. Every other article of the code (the sparing of the unarmed, the unmasking, the gift) is a corollary.

Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) defines play as a free activity standing outside "ordinary" life, limited in time and space, governed by rules that create a temporary and perfect order, and given to surrounding itself with secrecy. Its consecrated grounds (the arena, the card table, the temple, the stage, the court of justice, the "magic circle") are islands within which a special law obtains. The Yautja hunt satisfies every clause of the definition. It is bounded in time: Anna's folklore attaches the trophy-taking demon to the hot season[1], and the Thomases set the sequel in a Los Angeles gripped by gang war and heat wave precisely to create an ideal "hot spot" for the hunt[2]. It is bounded in space: the jungle, the city block, the preserve, the arena. It is governed by rules. And it is secret: the hunter cloaks not only its body but its traces, recovering its dead and its equipment.

Huizinga's most penetrating distinction concerns the violators of play. The cheat pretends to play and thereby acknowledges the magic circle; the spoil-sport shatters the play-world itself, and is therefore punished far more severely. The franchise's two most extreme acts are both spoil-sport acts, and they mark the limits within which the code lives. The self-destruct device is the hunter's refusal to let the matériel of the game pass into ordinary life: defeated, it

converts its own body and equipment into heat, so that nothing of the hunt survives outside the circle (Chapters Four and Five read this as expenditure and anti-capture). The nuclear strike that ends *Aliens vs. Predator: Requiem* (2007) is the state's spoil-sport act, abolishing the circle by abolishing the town that contained it. Huizinga's chapter on play and war adds a historical diagnosis. Archaic war, he argued, was agonal: it was fought by challenge and appointment, under codes of honour, as an ordeal whose outcome disclosed the judgment of the gods, whereas modern total war had expelled the play-element almost entirely. Writing in 1938, Huizinga believed the agonal warrior was disappearing. The franchise imagines him returning from the stars into the theaters of the covert Central American wars, the narcotics wars, and the corporate expeditions of the later installments, all of them wars that had long ceased to be play. The alien is the last practitioner of war as culture.

3.2 Disqualification: The Mercy That Is Contempt

The franchise's record of exemptions is consistent. In 1987 the hunter kills Hawkins and spares the guerrilla prisoner Anna; Dutch infers that it attacks only those it regards as threats and orders her to drop her weapon before she runs[1], glossing the inference in two words: no sport. In 1990 the hunter spares a drug lord's girlfriend in a penthouse massacre and, in the subway, kills Detective Lambert and the armed passengers but spares Leona Cantrell when its helmet's scanners register her pregnancy[2]. In *Prey* (2022) it ignores Naru and her brother Taabe, bound and set out as bait, and kills most of the French trappers who bound them[8]. The unarmed, the gravid, and the bound are exempted. They are not, however, *protected* in any humanitarian sense. They are non-players.

Nietzsche supplies the logic. In the first essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887, §10), the noble is distinguished from the man of ressentiment by his reverence for his enemies: he can tolerate only an enemy in whom there is nothing to despise and much to honour, and such reverence is already a bridge to love. The man of ressentiment, by contrast, invents "the evil enemy," the enemy as a moral category. The franchise draws the corollary with rigour: whoever offers nothing to honour offers nothing to hunt. The sparing of the unarmed is the noble's indifference to the despicable, and it is consistent with the parable of §13, in which the lambs' grudge against the birds of prey is answered by the birds' serene reply that they bear the lambs no ill will and even find them delicious. The Predator bears humanity no grudge. It is the franchise's founding image of violence without hatred, and therefore of violence without

ressentiment.

I call the hunted party that the code thus constitutes the **justa praeda**, the lawful prey: the being recognized as eligible to be hunted because it is armed, capable of counter-violence, and therefore worthy. The formula is modeled on the *justus hostis* of European public law (§3.4), and it redistributes the "two classes" of Connell's Rainsford. The world is no longer divided into hunters and huntees but into huntees and the disqualified. The humanitarian scale of value is inverted: to be spared is to be judged worthless, and to be hunted is to be honored. This inversion is what the dissertation means by *disqualification*, the name of the franchise's first phase.

The code is executed by sensor, and it is therefore a semiotics before it is an ethics. Chapter Two argued that the thermal gaze reduces every being to bare heat; the code is the grammar that reintroduces distinctions into that undifferentiated field. The helmet reads weapon, womb, and bond as signs of danger or of its absence, and classifies accordingly. Bare heat is the code's raw material; eligibility is its first articulation.

3.3 The Struggle for Pure Prestige

The philosophical template of eligibility is the life-and-death struggle of Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807, §§178–196). Self-consciousness exists only in being acknowledged by another self-consciousness, and the acknowledgment must be won by staking one's life: each party must show that it is not attached to its merely natural existence. The combatant who flinches before death becomes the bondsman; the victor becomes the lord. But the lord's victory is hollow, since the recognition he receives comes from a being he does not recognize as an equal. The Yautja code reads as a solution to the lord's impasse. By hunting only the armed, the hunter ensures that every kill is witnessed by a being capable of staking its life in return; by sparing the unarmed, it refuses to produce bondsmen. The classical Predator never enslaves. It kills, is killed, or gives. (The abductions of *Predators* and *Killer of Killers* are later mutations of the code under the pressure of capture, examined in Chapters Five and Eight.)

Alexandre Kojève's lectures of 1933–1939, published as *Introduction to the Reading of Hegel* (1947), radicalized the dialectic into an anthropology. Human desire is the desire for another's desire, and humanity is created in the "fight for pure prestige," the risk of biological life for a non-biological end. When the universal and homogeneous state ends history, the anthropogenic struggle ceases. In a note added to the book's second edition after a 1959 visit to Japan,

however, Kojève speculated that post-historical humanity might take the form not of a return to animality but of Japanese "snobbery": Noh theatre, the tea ceremony, flower arrangement, and a capacity for perfectly gratuitous suicide, in which the given is negated for the sake of purely formal values. The Yautja are the most exact image of Kojève's post-historical snob that modern fiction has produced. Theirs is a civilization beyond scarcity and beyond history that preserves the anthropogenic risk as pure form: the hunt is Noh played with live ammunition, and the self-destruct is a gratuitous *seppuku*. *Killer of Killers* (2025) stages the Kojèvean scene literally. In its Japanese segment, set in 1609, two brothers are ordered to duel for their father's succession; Kenji refuses, is scarred and disgraced, and lives thereafter in exile[12]. The refusal of the prestige struggle is answered by its return from the sky.

Francis Fukuyama, who popularized Kojève in "The End of History?" (1989) and *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992), recast the struggle in the Platonic vocabulary of *thymos*. *Megalothymia*, the desire to be recognized as superior, threatens liberal democracy, while *isothymia*, the desire to be recognized as equal, is satisfied by it; the danger of the post-historical order is that megalothymia, deprived of wars, either decays into the comfort of Nietzsche's "last man" or seeks outlets in sport, mountaineering, and enterprise. *Predator* premiered in June 1987, two years before Fukuyama's essay, and stages a meeting of two thymotic surpluses. Dutch's unit is historical megalothymia degraded into an instrument, deployed in a covert war on a pretext supplied by the CIA. The hunter is post-historical megalothymia ritualized, a species of interstellar alpinists for whom Earth's warriors are a north face.

3.4 Bracketing Beyond the Line

Carl Schmitt's *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950) argued that the *jus publicum Europaeum* achieved, between the sixteenth and nineteenth centuries, a *Hegung des Krieges*, a bracketing of war. War became a duel between sovereign states that recognized one another as *justi hostes*, just enemies equal in right; the enemy was no longer a criminal, and war was conducted according to forms. Schmitt was candid about the price. The bracketing held only within Europe. The "amity lines" drawn by early modern treaties marked a zone beyond which no peace and no law obtained, and the unbracketed violence of the colonial world was the condition of Europe's restraint.

The franchise's geography is the geography beyond the line: Val Verde, an invented Central American republic in which a CIA operation is conducted

under false pretenses; a near-future Los Angeles abandoned to cartel warfare; the Comanche plains of 1719, crossed by French trappers practicing an unregulated commerce in pelts; an extraterrestrial preserve. In each, the human institutions present behave as Schmitt's Europeans behaved beyond the line: Dillon lies to the unit he accompanies, Keyes's task force treats Los Angeles as a laboratory, the trappers stake captives as bait. The Predator is the only party that brings bracketing to these zones. It treats the colonial periphery as a field of *jus in bello*, and this is the franchise's most subversive irony: the alien sovereign restores to the colony the law that the metropole had withheld.

The Yautja nonetheless have no enemy in Schmitt's political sense. *The Concept of the Political* (1932) defines the political through the friend–enemy distinction and insists that the enemy is a public enemy (*hostis*), a collectivity that threatens one's form of life, not a private adversary (*inimicus*). The Yautja do not conquer, occupy, or exterminate; they do not fight humanity as a collective. Their adversary is a ludic-ethical category, individual, earned, and temporary. If the *justus hostis* was the enemy one recognized while fighting him, the *justa praeda* is the prey one recognizes by hunting it. Carl von Clausewitz opened *On War* (1832) by defining war as nothing but a duel (*Zweikampf*) on an extensive scale and, a few pages later, as the continuation of policy by other means. The Yautja hunt is the *Zweikampf* without the policy, war returned to its elementary form because it no longer continues anything. It is the franchise's quiet rejoinder to Clausewitz: subtract politics from war and the remainder is not peace but the hunt.

3.5 Dangerous Men: The Thermographic War Convention

Michael Walzer's *Just and Unjust Wars* (1977) grounds the war convention in a distinction between those who are dangerous and those who are not. Soldiers lose their immunity from attack by becoming "dangerous men"; noncombatants retain it because they are not engaged in the business of war. In a celebrated discussion of "naked soldiers," Walzer collects episodes in which combatants declined to kill enemies caught outside their role: an Austrian officer at his morning coffee in Emilio Lussu's memoir of the Italian front; the half-dressed fascist whom George Orwell saw running along a parapet holding up his trousers and did not shoot, because in that moment the man was visibly a fellow creature. Walzer concludes that such restraint is not strictly required, but that it reveals the root of the convention: a perception that the enemy is a man before he is a soldier.

The Predator's scanner is Walzer's convention mechanized. It reads danger, not identity: the weapon, not the uniform, the cause, or the nation. *Predator 2* is the purest Walzerian text in the corpus. Its hunter kills Colombian and Jamaican gangsters, police detectives, and the armed passengers of a subway car with perfect impartiality, while sparing the pregnant and the unarmed[2]. It knows nothing of *jus ad bellum*, the justice of a cause, and everything of *jus in bello*. It is the doctrine of the moral equality of combatants carried to its limit, in which every armed being is the equal of every other, whatever it fights for.

Jeff McMahan's *Killing in War* (2009) attacks precisely that doctrine. Liability to be killed, McMahan argues, depends on moral responsibility for an unjust threat, not on dangerousness as such; the soldier who fights in a just cause has done nothing to forfeit his rights. The Yautja code is a *reductio* of the position McMahan rejects: a war convention founded on dangerousness alone, indifferent to responsibility, which hunts defender and aggressor, policeman and gangster, with identical respect. The franchise's provocation lies here. We recognize our most widely held doctrine of fair combat in the monster's fairness, and we are horrified. Its real-world counterpart sharpens the irony. The signature strike conducted by the drone that borrowed the creature's name (Chapter One) kills by behavioural and thermal profile and abandons even Walzer's minimal discrimination; it reverts to bare heat. The fictional Predator superimposes a grammar of danger upon bare heat. The monster is more discriminating than the machine.

3.6 If It Bleeds: Equality, Recognition, and the Agonal Face

Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651, ch. 13) grounds natural equality in mutual vulnerability: the weakest has strength enough to kill the strongest, by secret machination or by confederacy with others. Equality, for Hobbes, is equality of killability. Dutch's "If it bleeds, we can kill it" is the Hobbesian axiom in a sentence, and the creature's luminous blood, which the effects crew made from glow-stick fluid[1], is the evidence that converts a god into a peer in the state of nature. The franchise grounds equality not in reason, soul, or dignity but in the capacity to bleed and to make bleed.

Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) derived an ethics from shared corporeal vulnerability: because all bodies are exposed to harm, all lives make a claim to be grieved. The franchise offers what may be termed **agonal precarity**, vulnerability apprehended not as an appeal but as a qualification. The hunter recognizes the vulnerability only of those who can strike back; a precariousness

that cannot answer violence with violence is, in its eyes, invisible.

The unmasking inverts Emmanuel Levinas. In *Totality and Infinity* (1961), the face is the epiphany of the other in its nakedness; it resists possession by an ethical rather than a physical resistance, and its first expression is the injunction against murder. When the Predator, judging Dutch a worthy opponent, sets aside its weapons and removes its mask to meet him hand to hand[1], the face appears not as a plea but as a challenge. I call it the **agonal face**: a face that says not "do not kill me" but "kill me if you can." Dutch's response, the obscene aesthetic verdict "You're one ugly motherfucker," is recognition in its profane form. One insults only *someone*.

Aristotle's *Poetics* (ch. 11) defines recognition (*anagnōrisis*) as a change from ignorance to knowledge and holds that the finest recognition coincides with a reversal of fortune (*peripeteia*), as in *Oedipus*. The unmasking is the franchise's recognition scene, and its reversal follows within minutes. The recognition is mutual: having recognized Dutch, the creature suspects the trap he has prepared and circumvents it, so that Dutch must spring the counterweight himself[1]. The turn requires the prey to expose himself to his own device.

The heroic template of this equalization is *Beowulf*. Before the night watch in Heorot, Beowulf renounces sword and mail: since Grendel knows nothing of weapons, he will grapple bare-handed and let God decide (ll. 677–87). The Predator's disarming repeats Beowulf's vow, and it realizes Plato's ideal of the sacred hunter who conquers with his own body (Chapter One). The outcome rhymes as well: Grendel's torn-off arm is hung beneath Heorot's roof as a token of victory (ll. 833–36), a trophy in the strictest sense. *Killer of Killers* makes the genealogy explicit when its Viking protagonist, Ursa, names the Yautja warlord who presides over the arena the "Grendel King"[12]. The warrior recognizes in the alien the monster of her own epic; the franchise recognizes in the epic its own code.

3.7 The Gift of the Enemy

The code culminates in a gift. At the end of *Predator 2*, the hunter's clan arrives to collect its dead, and its elder rewards Harrigan with a flintlock pistol engraved "Raphael Adolini 1715"[2]. In *AVP* (2004) the young hunter Scar marks Alexa Woods's cheek with the acid blood of a Xenomorph, the sign it bears itself, and after Scar's death the elders present her with a spear. The gift closes the dialectic that Hegel left open. Recognition is no longer extracted from a bondsman; it is bestowed upon a survivor.

Marcel Mauss's *Essay on the Gift* (1925) taught that a gift is never free: the thing given carries something of the giver, the *hau* of Mauss's Maori sources, and it compels a return. The Yautja gift is therefore also a promise, and Harrigan's closing intuition that the hunters will return[2] is Maussian in structure: the gift institutes a relation that a future encounter must settle. Bronisław Malinowski's *Argonauts of the Western Pacific* (1922) described the *kula*, in which shell necklaces and armshells circulate among the Massim islands and accrue renown from every hand they pass through without ever being permanently owned. The Adolini pistol is the franchise's *kula* valuable. *Prey* shows it in 1719, passing from the trappers' interpreter, Raphael Adolini, to Naru, who learns to fire it in exchange for treating his wounds[8]; by 1997 it is a Yautja heirloom, bestowed upon a Los Angeles detective. Igor Kopytoff's "cultural biography of things" (1986) asks what career an object has had and what that career reveals. The pistol's biography is the history of interspecies recognition. It is never possessed, only passed between those who have proven themselves.

3.8 The Code Turned Inward

Predator: Badlands (2025) opens with a citation from a Yautja codex: "Yautja are prey to none. Friend to none. Predator to all." It then shows the clan leader Njohrr ordering his son Kwei to kill his younger brother Dek, a runt judged too weak for the clan, and executing Kwei when he defies the order[14]. Here the code reveals its inward face. The criterion that, turned outward, disqualifies the unarmed human from being hunted, turned inward disqualifies the weak Yautja from living. Disqualification is the same operation in both directions, exclusion from the game, but its sign changes with the side of the circle on which it falls: outside, it confers immunity; inside, death. Plutarch's *Life of Lycurgus* (16) records that Spartan elders examined every newborn and sent the ill-formed to the place called the Apothetae, a chasm below Mount Taygetus. Chapter Six develops the Spartan analogy; it suffices here to note that every warrior code which defines worth by strength must eventually decide what to do with its own weak.

The code also has an ecology, and the ecology is not a predator's. Aldo Leopold's "Thinking Like a Mountain" (1949) recalls watching a "fierce green fire" die in the eyes of a wolf he had shot, and understanding only later that a mountain without wolves is ruined by its deer. Wolves, like other natural predators, take mostly the young, the old, and the sick. The Yautja code forbids exactly these quarry and targets the armed adult in its prime. That selection

pattern is the signature of a single species. Chris Darimont and colleagues, in "The Unique Ecology of Human Predators" (*Science*, 2015), showed that humans kill adult prey at rates far exceeding those of other predators and called humanity a global "super predator"; David Coltman and colleagues (*Nature*, 2003) argued that decades of trophy hunting of bighorn rams at Ram Mountain, Alberta, had selected for smaller horns. A code that hunts only the strongest is the ecology of the trophy hunter, and its long-run effect is selection against the very trait it honors. The Predator is anthropomorphic in its ecology before it is anthropomorphic in its body: it is the human trophy hunter's selective regime, returned upon the species that invented it.

The contradiction has a further consequence, which Nietzsche's "Homer's Contest" (1872) helps to formulate. The Greek agon, Nietzsche argued, required a plurality of competitors, and ostracism originally served to remove the one who towered over all the rest so that the contest of forces could continue. The Yautja face the inverse problem: by killing the best, they deplete the field of worthy opponents. The franchise's answer is husbandry. In *AVP* the hunters keep a captive Xenomorph queen beneath an Antarctic pyramid to breed quarry for their initiates; in *Predators* (2010) they stock a planetary preserve with imported killers; in *Killer of Killers* they hold in suspended animation the warriors who have killed their kind, to be released into the arena[12]. The code, carried to its conclusion, produces its own apparatus of capture. Chapter Five follows the human version of that apparatus; it is worth recording here that the hunters themselves are its first architects.

Badlands ends by rewriting the code from within. On the death planet Genna, the synthetic Thia teaches Dek about Earth's wolves; Dek mistakes the "alpha" for the wolf that kills the most, and learns at last that the alpha is the one who protects the pack[14]. The correction coincides with ethology's own. L. David Mech, whose early work had helped to popularize the alpha wolf, argued in 1999 that the dominance model derived from captive wolves misdescribed wild packs, which are families whose "alphas" are simply the breeding parents. The film's revision of the code passes through the revision of the very ethological myth, dominance as nature's law, that the twentieth century had projected onto animals, as it had projected the hunting hypothesis onto its ancestors (Chapter One). Dek returns to Yautja Prime having found his own clan with Thia and the alien juvenile Bud[14], and the code's criterion of eligibility yields to a criterion of protection.

The code may now be stated in full. It is a grammar of eligibility applied to bare heat, and it performs four operations: *qualification* (the armed),

disqualification (the unarmed, the gravid, the bound, the weak), *recognition* (the unmasking and the gift), and *expenditure* (the self-destruct). Its first phase disqualifies; its second is captured; its third rewrites eligibility as kinship. The next chapter turns from the question of who may be hunted to the question of what is done with the hunted.

IV

Chapter Four

Tropaic Predation

4.1 Trophic and Tropaic
4.2 The Tropaion: Turning, Hanging, Decay
4.3 The Restitution of the Bones
4.4 The Flayed Body
4.5 Dark Trophies: The Hanging Tree
4.6 The Slaughterhouse and the Civilizing Process
4.7 Ventriloquial Predation
4.8 Expenditure: The Potlatch of the Self
4.9 The Career of the Trophy

The Predator does not eat what it kills. It flays, hangs, collects, and displays, and in doing so it moves the human from the trophic order, in which bodies are food, to the tropaic order, in which bodies are signs. This chapter names that operation **tropaic predation**: predation whose product is not nourishment but a trophy, and whose horror is not consumption but commemoration. It follows the trophy from the Greek battlefield through the archaic economies of the hunted body, the dark trophies of modern war and the American hanging tree, the slaughterhouse in which modernity hides its killing, and the voice that the hunter steals. It ends with the self-destruct as sovereign expenditure and with the career of the trophy across the franchise's three phases.

4.1 Trophic and Tropaic

Two Greek roots, near-homophones in their English derivatives, divide the field. *Trophē*, nourishment, from *trephein*, to feed, gives ecology its "trophic levels," the rungs of the food chain through which, in Raymond Lindeman's "The Trophic-Dynamic Aspect of Ecology" (1942), energy passes and is degraded at every transfer. *Tropaion*, from *trepein*, to turn, gives the trophy. The thermal gaze of Chapter Two perceives exactly what Lindeman's ecology measures, the energy of living bodies, yet the hunter extracts from its prey no calories at all. It takes signs. The franchise has noticed its own paradox. In *The Predator* (2018), the evolutionary biologist Casey Bracket objects that a creature which hunts for sport and keeps trophies rather than eating its kills is not a predator but a sports hunter; the government agent Traeger replies that the name was chosen by vote because it sounded cooler[7]. The joke is exact. The franchise's monster is misnamed, and the misnomer conceals its essence: it is not a trophic but a tropaic predator.

The distinction produces two horrors. Val Plumwood, in the crocodile's grip, discovered the horror of being *food*, of re-entering the trophic chain from which Western thought had exempted the human body by fiat. The Xenomorph belongs to this order of monsters, as do the shark and the zombie, and so does the Kalisk of *Badlands*, which swallows the synthetic Tessa alive[14]. The Predator offers a second horror: that of being *kept*. Plumwood's crocodile wanted her as calories; the Predator wants the Green Beret as a skull. The first horror abolishes the person in metabolism; the second preserves the person as a sign in another's archive. Tropaic predation is the more disturbing because it is the more human. Among predators, human beings are the great keepers of the dead.

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4.2 The Tropaion: Turning, Hanging, Decay

The Greek *tropaion* was raised on the battlefield at the place where the enemy had turned (*tropē*) to flee. Victors stripped the arms of the fallen and hung helmet, cuirass, and shield upon a tree trunk or stake, so that the armor formed the effigy of an empty warrior, and dedicated the whole to Zeus Tropaios, Zeus of the Turning. W. Kendrick Pritchett's survey in *The Greek State at War* (vol. 2, 1974) documents the custom's essential feature: impermanence. The trophy was meant to decay. Plutarch's *Roman Questions* (37) asks why trophies were allowed to fall into ruin without repair and answers that it would be invidious to perpetuate the memory of enmity. Cicero's *De Inventione* (2.69–70) cites the Thebans, who, having defeated the Spartans, erected a trophy of bronze and were arraigned before the Amphictyonic Council for violating the custom that memorials of war be temporary.

The franchise's first image of horror is a *tropaion*. In 1987 the unit finds three skinned corpses hung high in the trees near a helicopter wreck, and Dutch identifies them as Green Berets[1]. The Greek form is preserved and its content literalized. What is hung at the place of the rout is not the armor of the dead but the dead themselves, stripped of their outermost armor, the skin. The trophy is also, as in Greece, perishable: the hung bodies are left to the jungle, while the durable part of the kill, the skull with its spine attached, is carried away. *Predator 2* shows where it goes. The hunter's vessel holds a wall of skulls from many species, among which the production team placed the skull of a Xenomorph[2]. The franchise thus contains both classical regimes of the trophy: the perishable field *tropaion* of the Greeks and the permanent monument for which the Thebans were arraigned, which Rome would make the architecture of empire in the *Tropaeum Alpium* at La Turbie.

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Rome also supplies the trophy's highest grade. The *spolia opima*, arms stripped from an enemy commander killed in single combat by a Roman commander, were dedicated to Jupiter Feretrius and, by tradition, won only three times: by Romulus, by Aulus Cornelius Cossus, and by Marcus Claudius Marcellus in 222 BCE. The narrative architecture of the franchise follows the logic of the *spolia opima*. The hunter kills the subordinates first and reserves the leader for the duel: Dutch, the "most dangerous man" of the screenplay's conception; King Willie, the Jamaican gang leader whom the Predator duels and beheads, taking the head as a trophy[2]; Harrigan, the lieutenant who charges into the firefight ahead of his officers. The richest trophy is the commander's, and the commander's death is the climax of the hunt.

4.3 The Restitution of the Bones

The anthropology of hunting peoples complicates the trophy's meaning. Karl Meuli's essay "Griechische Opferbräuche" (1946) collected from circumpolar hunting cultures a cluster of rites he called the "comedy of innocence" (*Unschuldskomödie*): hunters apologized to the slain animal, blamed the kill on others, and gathered its bones, above all the skull, to be set up on a pole, a tree, or a platform so that the animal might be reconstituted and return. Walter Burkert's *Homo Necans* (1972) traced Greek sacrifice to this Paleolithic matrix and read the setting-up of skull and bones as an act of restitution answering the guilt of killing. The Ainu *iyomante* gives the matrix its most elaborate form. A bear cub is captured and raised in the village, fed and cared for as a member of the household; after a year or two it is ceremonially killed, and its spirit, understood as a divine visitor (*kamuy*) that had worn the bear's body as a garment, is sent home to the world of the gods with gifts, while its adorned skull is set upon the altar.

The comparison clarifies what the Predator's trophies are not. They are not restitutions: no rite returns the skull to its owner's world, and no apology accompanies the kill. They are commemorations without guilt. Yet the Ainu rite also anticipates the franchise's endpoint. Its prey is first *familiarized*, raised as kin, and only then killed and honored, which is the structure of what Carlos Fausto calls familiarizing predation (Chapter Nine). The archaic trophy belongs to a regime that binds killer and killed into kinship. The franchise begins with the trophy torn from that regime and ends, in *Badlands*, by restoring it.

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4.4 The Flayed Body

Flaying is the franchise's signature violence, and Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) explains why it horrifies. The abject is what disturbs identity, system, and order by confounding the boundary between inside and outside, and the corpse is its supreme instance. The skin is the boundary itself. To flay a body is to abolish the frontier that makes it a self, exposing as surface what should remain interior. The Greek imagination already joined flaying to the agon. Marsyas, the satyr who challenged Apollo to a contest of music and lost, was flayed alive; Xenophon (*Anabasis* 1.2.8) and Herodotus (7.26) report that his skin was displayed at Celaenae, and Hellenistic sculpture showed him hanging from a pine before the knife. The first flayed body of the Western tradition is the trophy of a contest with a god, hung from a tree. Ovid's Marsyas cries out against being torn from himself (*quid me mihi detrahis?*, *Metamorphoses* 6.385), and the cry names what the flayed trophy performs: the subtraction of a self from its own body.

The Predator's practice is the exact inverse of the modern trophy hunter's. Taxidermy, as perfected by Carl Akeley for the American Museum of Natural History, keeps the skin and discards the body, mounting the hide over a sculpted mannequin to preserve the animal's appearance. The Predator discards the skin and keeps the armature. Its signature trophy, the skull drawn out with the spinal column attached, preserves not the surface but the structure, and specifically the housing of the central nervous system: the organ of vigilance, fear, and resolve, the very faculty that Ortega's hunt was designed to test. Taxidermy collects the body as image. The Predator collects the body as nerve.

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4.5 Dark Trophies: The Hanging Tree

The trophy that the franchise hangs in its trees has a modern history that the films seldom acknowledge. Simon Harrison's *Dark Trophies: Hunting and the Enemy Body in Modern War* (2012) shows that the taking of enemy body parts by Western soldiers, from the skulls collected in the Pacific War to the ears taken in Vietnam, was patterned on recreational hunting and flourished where the enemy had been racialized as animal. *Life*'s "Picture of the Week" for 22 May 1944 showed a young woman in Arizona contemplating a Japanese skull sent to her by her Navy boyfriend; in 2003 the *Toledo Blade* documented atrocities committed in 1967 by the Tiger Force reconnaissance platoon in Vietnam, including the collection of ears. *Predator* returns this practice upon its practitioners. The skinned Green Berets in the canopy belong to the same special-operations culture whose wars had produced the trophy economy, and Dutch's bond with Dillon was forged in Vietnam[1]. The dark trophy comes home.

A second and graver history lies closer. For an American audience, the human body hung from a tree as a trophy is the central image of the lynching archive: the spectacle lynchings of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, attended by crowds, photographed for souvenir postcards, and accompanied by the taking of body parts, as documented in *Without Sanctuary: Lynching Photography in America* (2000). Abel Meeropol's poem "Strange Fruit," recorded by Billie Holiday in 1939, gave the image its canonical name. The franchise draws on this iconography without confronting it. *Predator 2* sharpens the problem by suspending its flayed corpses among the Black and Latino gangs of a future Los Angeles, and Roger Ebert, reviewing the film, discerned in the creature's design subliminal cues that linked the menace to Black men[2]. Two readings are available, and the films support both. In the allegorical reading, the alien sovereign compels a white commando culture to undergo what American sovereignty did to others. In the critical reading, the franchise converts the most charged image in American history into aestheticized spectacle and assigns it to an alien, displacing the historical perpetrators. A responsible interpretation must hold both; Chapter Nine returns to the problem among the franchise's limits.

Donna Haraway's "Teddy Bear Patriarchy" (1984) supplies the institutional frame. Akeley's African Hall at the American Museum of Natural History, she argues, staged nature as a permanent tableau constituted by the hunter's gaze: the mounted gorilla, killed and posed, offered the white male viewer a vision of nature as origin, purity, and mirror. The trophy wall of *Predator 2* is Akeley's hall turned inside out. In its diorama the human skull hangs beside the skulls of other species, catalogued by a gaze for which humanity is one exhibit among

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many. Joseph Conrad had already imagined the colonial version of this collection. In *Heart of Darkness* (1899), the ornamental knobs on the posts around Kurtz's station prove, through Marlow's glasses, to be human heads. The Predator is Kurtz without the hypocrisy of the civilizing mission: it keeps the heads and files no report.

4.6 The Slaughterhouse and the Civilizing Process

Norbert Elias's *The Civilizing Process* (1939) traced the withdrawal of killing and carving from view. In medieval and early modern Europe the whole animal, or large parts of it, was carved at the table by the host; by the nineteenth century carving had retreated to the kitchen and the butcher's shop, and the dish was presented so that it no longer recalled the animal it had been. The threshold of repugnance advanced, and the distasteful was removed behind the scenes of social life. Philippe Ariès described the corresponding sequestration of human death in the hospital, the "forbidden death" of the twentieth century. Upton Sinclair's *The Jungle* (1906) exposed the Chicago stockyards in which industrial killing had been concentrated, and Timothy Pachirat's *Every Twelve Seconds* (2011), an ethnography of an industrial slaughterhouse in which an animal is killed every twelve seconds, argues that such killing depends on a "politics of sight": the division of labor confines the kill to a handful of workers and conceals it from everyone else. Carol J. Adams's *The Sexual Politics of Meat* (1990) names the semiotic result. In meat, the animal becomes an "absent referent," its death made invisible in the product.

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Predator 2 stages its central trap inside this institution. Harrigan traces his partner's killer to a slaughterhouse, and Keyes's task force waits for the hunter there, among the hanging carcasses[2]. The setting is not incidental. The slaughterhouse is the place where modernity conceals its killing; the Predator is the being that displays its own. The tropaic predator reverses the civilizing process: it carves at the table, it hangs its kill in the public square, and it keeps the referent present. Its trophy is the antithesis of meat. Where meat erases the animal, the skull insists on it. The franchise's horror is in this sense historical: it is the return of the visible kill to a civilization that had organized itself around not seeing.

4.7 Ventriloquial Predation

The Predator takes a second trophy, invisible and audible: the voice. In 1987 it records fragments of its victims' speech and replays them to lure the living, and as it dies it arms its self-destruct device to the sound of Billy's laughter, recorded earlier in the film. *Predator 2* extends the repertoire with taunts borrowed from the city. Eduardo Viveiros de Castro's *From the Enemy's Point of View* (1986; English 1992) provides the anthropological key. Among the Araweté of Amazonia, a man who has killed an enemy enters a period of seclusion during which the dead enemy's spirit teaches him songs, and in the war songs that the killer then performs it is the slain enemy who speaks, referring to the Araweté as his enemies. To kill is to acquire the enemy's point of view and to sing from it. I call the franchise's version of this structure **ventriloquial predation**: predation as the capture of the victim's perspective through its voice. Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) observed that phonographic recording gave the dead an indefinitely reproducible voice. The hunter's helmet is a phonograph with mandibles, an archive of last words.

The franchise's later phases move from ventriloquism to speech. *The Predator* (2018) supplies, for the first time, subtitles for conversations between Yautja, and its larger hunter delivers an ultimatum to the humans through the government's own translation software[7]. *Badlands* gives the species a language with consistent grammar, devised by the linguist Britton Watkins[14], who also voiced the Grendel King of *Killer of Killers*[12]. The trophy of voice yields to the hunter's own voice. A creature that once spoke only in the words of its dead now speaks in the first person, and Chapter Nine argues that this grammatical change is the franchise's deepest transformation.

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4.8 Expenditure: The Potlatch of the Self

Georges Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) opens with the sun. Solar energy is the source of life's exuberance, and the sun gives without return; living matter receives more energy than it needs for growth, and the surplus must be spent, either gloriously, in luxury, festival, and sacrifice, or catastrophically, in war. Bataille calls *sovereign* the moment valued for itself, independent of utility and of the future, and *servile* the subordination of the present to production. The Yautja hunt is sovereign expenditure in Bataille's strict sense. It mobilizes interstellar technology to no productive end: it neither feeds nor conquers nor accumulates, and its only product is a sign. It is also solar in Bataille's sense. The hunter arrives in the hottest years, perceives life as heat, and leaves the world as heat.

The self-destruct is expenditure at its limit, and Marcel Mauss's account of the potlatch explains its form. Among the Kwakwaka'wakw (Kwakiutl) of the Northwest Coast, rival chiefs asserted rank by destroying property, above all the great engraved coppers, which were broken or thrown into the sea to shame a rival who could not match the destruction. The defeated Predator performs a potlatch of the self. It destroys its most valuable property, its body and its technology, rather than let either pass to the victor, and it laughs as it does so. The victor is denied his trophy: Dutch survives with nothing to hang. The detonation is not merely a weapon. It is a refusal of capture and an assertion of sovereignty over one's own death, the defeated hunter's last turn of the game against the winner. *Predator 2* interrupts the rite. On a rooftop, Harrigan severs the device with the hunter's own disc[2], and when he later kills it, its clan does not detonate but gives. The interrupted potlatch becomes a gift exchange, the arc of Mauss's essay compressed into a single film.

4.9 The Career of the Trophy

The trophy has a career across the franchise, and its stages coincide with the dialectic of Chapter Eight. In the first phase, the hunter takes trophies and denies them to its prey: it hangs the flayed, collects the skulls, and, defeated, spends itself so that nothing remains to be taken. In the second phase, the trophy becomes a *specimen*. Keyes's task force seeks to capture the creature alive for study[2]. In *The Predator*, a government laboratory lays a hunter on an examination table, and Casey Bracket, inverting Dutch's verdict on its face, pronounces it beautiful. The same film reinterprets the skull-and-spine trophy as the harvesting of genetic material for hybridization, and the government's display case of captured technology holds the Xenomorph-tail spear that Alexa Woods carried in *AVP*[7]. The gift has become an exhibit. The trophy has entered the museum, the laboratory, and the market, where Chapter Five will follow it.

In the third phase, the prey takes the trophy, and the trophy recovers its archaic function. Naru severs the hunter's head and paints her face with its glowing blood[8]. In *Badlands*, the Kalisk's child Bud tears off the head and spine of the corporate synthetic Tessa, performing the franchise's signature trophy-taking on the agent of capital; Dek returns to Yautja Prime with Tessa's skull and presents it to his father as a trophy, demanding his own cloaking device as reward, and when Njohrr refuses and is defeated, the grown Bud bites off the father's head[14]. Here the trophy is no longer commemoration, and no longer specimen, but token: the proof of a passage that admits its bearer to a

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community, as in the Ainu rite and in every initiation that requires the novice to bring back a sign of the kill. In Western modernity the history of the trophy ran from the perishable *tropaion* to the permanent museum specimen. The franchise runs it backward, from specimen to token of kinship, and re-sacralizes the trophy in the process. The human begins the franchise as a skull on the hunter's wall and ends it as the taker of the hunter's head, and then as the founder of a clan.

The trophy never travels alone. At every stage of its career an institution waits to seize it, and the next chapter names that institution.

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V

Chapter Five

The Apparatus of Capture

5.1 War Machine and Apparatus
5.2 A Genealogy of Capture
5.3 Standing-Reserve: The Expendable Asset
5.4 The Forest and the Preserve
5.5 Blacking: The Poacher in the Sovereign's Forest
5.6 The Telluric Partisan
5.7 The Heat Bloom: Capture by Lure
5.8 Acquisitions: The Genome and the Hottest Century
5.9 The Drone That Borrowed the Name
5.10 The Triangle Dissolved

The antagonist of every installment is not the hunter. It is an institution that stands between hunter and hunted and seeks to convert the hunt into a resource: an intelligence agency, a federal task force, an industrialist, an army, a laboratory, a corporation, a colonial trading party, and finally the Yautja's own wardens. Following Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, this chapter names that institution the **apparatus of capture**. The franchise's politics is a triangle. Hunter and prey are bound to each other by a code of eligibility and recognition; the apparatus is bound by none, and in every film it attempts to capture both, baiting the prey and seizing the hunter.

5.1 War Machine and Apparatus

In *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980), Deleuze and Guattari oppose the "war machine," a nomadic assemblage exterior to the State, to the State apparatus that seeks to appropriate it. The war machine occupies smooth space, which it traverses without dividing; the State striates space, measuring, enclosing, and taxing it. The war machine does not have war as its object, and it becomes a military institution only when the State captures it. The apparatus of capture, the subject of their thirteenth plateau, is the State's essential operation: it appropriates what it did not produce, by rent, tax, and stockpile, and overcodes it. The Yautja are a war machine in this exact sense. They hold no territory on Earth, levy no tribute, occupy nothing, and traverse jungle, rooftop, and plain as smooth space. Deleuze and Guattari distinguish the weapon, which belongs to free action and speed, from the tool, which belongs to work and gravity. The Yautja's technology is entirely weapon; it produces nothing. Every human institution in the franchise wants to turn it into a tool.

The apparatus wants four things in turn: the hunter's body, its weapons, its genome, and finally the regenerative life of the beings it hunts. The self-destruct device, read in Chapter Four as a potlatch, is in this register the war machine's refusal of capture. The hunter that cannot escape the apparatus abolishes the booty.

5.2 A Genealogy of Capture

Every installment places an agent of capture between hunter and hunted, and the object it seeks rises across four decades from the human body to the genome.

Year	Film	Agent of capture	Object sought	Means	Outcome
2025	*Predator: Badlands*	Weyland-Yutani; the synthetic Tessa, answering to MU/TH/UR	The Kalisk's regenerative power	Cryogenic capture; experiment on Dek	Tessa swallowed by the Kalisk; her skull becomes Dek's trophy
2025	*Predator: Killer of Killers*	A Yautja warlord, the "Grendel King"	Humans who have killed Yautja	Abduction; suspended animation; explosive collars; arena	Two escape; Ursa returned to stasis
2022	*Prey*	French fur trappers	Bison pelts; the creature	Mass skinning; captives staked as bait	Slaughtered; their leader abandons his men
2018	*The Predator*	Project Stargazer (Traeger)	Bodies, technology, genetic material	Laboratory; display case	Traeger killed by a captured plasma caster
2010	*Predators*	Yautja keepers of a preserve	"Worthy prey" from many worlds	Abduction; planetary game preserve	The cycle resumes as new prey parachute in
2007	*Aliens vs. Predator: Requiem*	U.S. military (Colonel Stevens); Ms. Yutani	Containment; the hunter's plasma pistol	Nuclear strike staged as evacuation	Gunnison destroyed; weapon passed to Yutani
2004	*AVP: Alien vs. Predator*	Charles Bishop Weyland	A buried pyramid, claimed in his name	Expedition drawn by a "heat bloom"	Weyland killed; the heat bloom was Yautja bait
1990	*Predator 2*	Keyes's federal task force	The living hunter, for study	Thermally shielded trap in a slaughterhouse	Task force slaughtered
1987	*Predator*	The CIA (Dillon)	A guerrilla camp; the unit as "expendable asset"	Deception	Dillon killed

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Read down the table, the agent changes institutional form without changing function. Read across it, the object of capture ascends from the expendable human to the hunter's corpse, its weapon, its genome, and the regenerative power of life itself. Two rows break the pattern, and they are decisive: in *Predators* and *Killer of Killers* the apparatus is Yautja. The hunters have built their own preserves and prisons. The war machine does not remain exterior for ever; in the franchise's second phase it is captured from within.

5.3 Standing-Reserve: The Expendable Asset

Martin Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) names the essence of modern technology *Gestell*, enframing: a mode of revealing that challenges everything forth as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, available on call for further ordering. The Rhine becomes a water-power supplier; the forest becomes cellulose; and, Heidegger observes, the current talk of human resources shows that the human being is not exempt. Dillon's confession that he regarded Dutch's men as an "expendable asset" is the franchise's founding statement of enframing. It has a precedent in the sibling franchise: the special order transmitted by the computer MU/TH/UR in *Alien* (1979), which declares the crew of the *Nostromo* expendable for the sake of the specimen. *Badlands* closes the circle, giving MU/TH/UR a voice as the overseer to whom the synthetic Tessa answers, and threatening Tessa herself with decommissioning should she fail[14]. Even capital's instruments are standing-reserve.

The contrast with the hunter is exact, and it is not flattering to either party. The apparatus disposes of the strong as resources; the code, as Chapter Three showed, disposes of the weak as unworthy. Both are regimes of disposability, and the franchise's third phase will reject both. But they differ in what they see. The code sees a *someone* whose danger makes it worthy; the apparatus sees a *something* whose utility makes it available. *Prey* stages the difference on the open plain. Naru comes upon a field of bison skinned for their pelts and left to rot, killed with firearms by French trappers[9]. The image is historically telescoped. Critics have noted that the French presence on the southern plains in 1719 is anachronistic[9], and the mass skinning belongs more properly to the American hide hunt of the 1870s, which reduced the continent's bison from tens of millions to a remnant and left the bones to be gathered and ground for fertilizer and bone char. The film projects the industrial standing-reserve backward onto the colonial frontier. The trappers are the apparatus in its commercial form, and their field of carcasses is the franchise's anti-trophy: a mass killing that keeps nothing but the commodity.

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5.4 The Forest and the Preserve

The English word *forest* descends from medieval Latin *forestis*, most plausibly from *foris*, "outside": the forest was not, in the first instance, woodland but land placed outside the common law and reserved under forest law for the king's hunting. William the Conqueror's afforestations made the institution notorious. The *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle*, in its verses on his death in 1087, records that he decreed blinding for whoever slew hart or hind and loved the tall deer as though he were their father. The sovereign's love for his game, like Nietzsche's birds of prey and their lambs, is the love of the hunter for what it is entitled to kill. The Charter of the Forest of 1217 restored common rights within the royal forests and provided that no one should lose life or limb for the king's venison.

The planet of *Predators* (2010) is a forest in the strict medieval sense: a space outside any law but the hunter's, onto which the Yautja drop prey abducted from other worlds[6]. The film's selection of human game is a census of Earth's own zones of exception: an enforcer for the Los Zetas cartel, a Spetsnaz commando taken from the war in Chechnya, an Israeli Defense Forces sniper, a Revolutionary United Front officer from Sierra Leone, a San Quentin death-row inmate days from execution, an Inagawa-kai yakuza enforcer, a mercenary, and a physician who proves to be a serial killer[6]. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) defines the sacred man of archaic Roman law as one who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide, and identifies the camp as the space in which the state of exception becomes the rule. The preserve harvests the exceptions of human sovereignty and subjects them to a new law, the law of the hunt. Agamben also recalls the outlaw of Germanic and Anglo-Saxon law, declared a "wolf's head" and killable by anyone, the man who has become game. Every figure dropped into the preserve was already, on Earth, a wolf's head in waiting.

Only one of them finds the preserve a home. The physician Edwin, having paralyzed his companion with a neurotoxic plant, announces his intention to remain on the planet[6]. The native of the camp is the murderer whose life was already a private state of exception. Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) describes the colony as a zone in which sovereignty consists in the right to kill and in which populations inhabit "death-worlds." The franchise names its planets accordingly: *Badlands* calls Genna a death planet[14]. The canine imagery of the preserve completes the genealogy of the method. The film's surviving veteran, Noland, likens the feud between the larger and smaller Yautja to the difference between wolves and dogs, and the hunters run domesticated alien beasts as hounds[6]. The *kynēgetēs* is, etymologically, the leader of dogs. In the

preserve the cynegetic order becomes literal: hunters, hounds, and the hunted, under a sovereign who loves his game.

5.5 Blacking: The Poacher in the Sovereign's Forest

E. P. Thompson's *Whigs and Hunters: The Origin of the Black Act* (1975) reconstructed the episode in which the forest law returned with modern violence. In the early 1720s, bands of men with blackened faces, the "Waltham Blacks," took deer from the royal forests and private parks of Hampshire and Windsor. Parliament answered with the Black Act of 1723, which created some fifty capital offences, among them being found armed and with a disguised or blackened face in a forest, chase, or park. What the Charter of the Forest had abolished in 1217, the Whig oligarchy restored.

Dutch's mud is blacking. Having discovered that the coating hides him from the hunter's thermal sight, he blackens himself to stalk the sovereign in the sovereign's own preserve, as the Waltham Blacks stalked the king's deer. The franchise thereby inverts the relation of poacher and quarry: the blacked commoner hunts not the sovereign's game but the sovereign. Thompson's celebrated conclusion supplies the second half of the analogy. The law, he argued, was an instrument of class power, yet the rule of law was also a real constraint upon power, which the ruled could invoke against their rulers; it was not merely a mask. The Yautja code behaves exactly so. It serves the hunter and it binds the hunter, and the prey survive by turning its rules against their author. Dutch sends Anna to safety unarmed because he has read the code; Naru, having learned that the hunter's targeting system answers to hostile movement, turns that system upon its owner. The code is the hunter's law, and it is also the prey's only charter.

5.6 The Telluric Partisan

Carl Schmitt's *Theory of the Partisan* (1963) identifies four criteria of the figure who escapes the bracketing of war: irregularity, intensified political commitment, mobility, and a *telluric* character, a defensive attachment to a particular soil. Schmitt feared that technology would sever the partisan from the earth and leave only the absolute enmity of the deracinated fighter. The franchise's counter-hunters are telluric partisans in the most literal sense available. Dutch fights with what the jungle provides and, plastered in mud, becomes earth; Naru defends her people's ground with knowledge of its plants and animals; Harrigan defends a city that his own government has abandoned to its cartels. The hunter, by contrast, is the absolute irregular, without uniform, state, or territory, and the apparatus is the absolute deracinator.

The apparatus's final answer to the telluric is to abolish the soil. In *Aliens vs. Predator: Requiem*, the survivors are summoned to the center of Gunnison by the promise of an airlift; what arrives is a tactical nuclear strike that destroys the town, the invaders, and the citizens together. Afterward, Colonel Stevens hands the hunter's plasma pistol to Ms. Yutani, who remarks that the world is not ready for such technology; Stevens replies that it is not intended for this world[4].

◀ v In the franchise's crossover continuity, the Company that will declare the *Nostromo*'s crew expendable is founded on an act of capture: a weapon taken from a war machine and transferred from a state that had just annihilated its own citizens.

5.7 The Heat Bloom: Capture by Lure

AVP (2004) opens with a satellite belonging to Charles Bishop Weyland detecting a "heat bloom" beneath the ice of Bouvetøya and, through thermal imaging, a pyramid buried far below. Terminally ill, Weyland wants the discovery claimed in his name; the expedition he funds learns too late that the heat bloom was bait, set by the Yautja to draw humans to the pyramid as hosts for the quarry of their initiates[3]. The episode is the franchise's most compact parable of extraction. The corporation's satellite sees as the hunter sees, by heat, and the hunters exploit the resemblance: they lure the apparatus with the very signature it was built to seek. Corporate desire, for discovery, priority, and a name, is the bait's attractor. The same episode adds a clause to the code. Scar at first spares Weyland because of his illness[3]: the sick, like the unarmed and the gravid, are disqualified.

Baiting is the apparatus's characteristic technique. Dillon baits Dutch with a false rescue; Keyes baits the hunter in the slaughterhouse; the French trappers stake Naru and Taabe as bait; the army baits Gunnison with an airlift; the Grendel King fits his captives with explosive collars and baits champions against one another[12]. The classical hunter, by contrast, is indifferent to bait. In *Prey* it passes the bound captives by and kills their captors[9]. The code makes the hunter immune to the apparatus's lure, because the lure offers only what the code disqualifies. The counter-hunter learns the lesson in both directions: Naru, who refused to be bait, later uses a trapper as bait to approach the hunter[9].

5.8 Acquisitions: The Genome and the Hottest Century

The Predator (2018) gives the apparatus its most explicit self-description. Its agent, Traeger, defines his work as "acquisitions": catching whatever falls out of the sky. His laboratory reinterprets the hunter's skull-and-spine trophies as the harvesting of genetic material, and he explains the intensifying visits by climate change: humanity, on his account, has only a few generations left before a warming planet destroys it, and the hunters are collecting human genetic material while it lasts, perhaps with a view to colonizing an Earth made hot enough to suit them[7]. The thermal allegory that began with Anna's seasonal demon here becomes explicit. The hottest years become the hottest century, and the demon of the hot season becomes the demon of the Anthropocene. The hunters themselves have become an apparatus. The larger, gene-enhanced hunter acts as police, pursuing a renegade who had defected to bring humanity an armor designed to kill Yautja, and destroying a crashed ship so that the government cannot recover its technology; Traeger dies when a captured plasma caster he cannot control discharges into his own head[7]. The captor is destroyed by the captured.

Michel Foucault's lectures of 1975–76 described the emergence of a biopower that takes life itself, at the level of the species, as its object. The 2018 film depicts biopolitics on an interstellar scale: the genome as standing-reserve, the trophy as sample, the hunt as harvest. *Badlands* takes the final step. Weyland-Yutani seeks to capture the Kalisk for its regenerative power, which Tessa calls a potential miracle for humanity[14]. Marx described capital as dead labor that lives only by sucking living labor, vampire-like; the franchise's true vampire is not its monster, which never feeds on its prey, but the apparatus, which wants the blood that regenerates.

5.9 The Drone That Borrowed the Name

The nineteenth-century Cumbrian hunting song "D'ye ken John Peel" follows the chase "from a view to a death in the morning." Matt Cartmill took the line for his history of the hunt (Chapter One), and the geographer Derek Gregory adapted it for "From a View to a Kill: Drones and Late Modern War" (2011), which analyzes the scopic regime of remote warfare and the bureaucratic "kill chain" that connects the analyst's screen to the strike. The coincidence of titles is diagnostic. Contemporary targeted killing narrates itself as a hunt. Grégoire Chamayou's *Drone Theory* (2013) argues that the armed drone completes the transformation of war into manhunt by abolishing the reciprocity of risk that made combat a duel.

The United States Air Force named its first armed drone the MQ-1 Predator. Whatever the provenance of the name, the act is the apparatus's ultimate capture: the appropriation not of the monster's body, weapon, or genome but of its name, emptied of its code. The drone retains the thermal gaze and discards everything Chapter Three found in the hunter's ethic: the risk, the face, the disqualification of the harmless, the gift. It is the hunt as the apparatus has always wanted it, without the hunter.

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5.10 The Triangle Dissolved

The franchise's politics can now be stated. In the first phase, the apparatus stands behind the prey and betrays it: the CIA sends Dutch's unit into the jungle as expendable assets, and the federal task force uses Los Angeles as a trap. In the second phase, the apparatus seizes the hunt itself, in the corporation's pyramid, the army's nuclear strike, the laboratory's display case, and the Yautja's own preserve. In the third phase, hunter and prey ally against the apparatus. Dek and the synthetic Thia, joined by an alien juvenile, destroy the Weyland-Yutani base; the three champions of *Killer of Killers*, ordered to kill one another, refuse and turn on the warlord who holds them[12]. The triangle collapses into alliance, and alliance becomes kinship. Chapter Nine argues that kinship is the franchise's answer to capture: the only relation that the apparatus cannot convert into standing-reserve is the one in which the hunter and the hunted have become family.

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Chapter Six

Mythic Homologies

6.1 The Films' Own Mythographers
6.2 The Solstitial Hunt: The Wild Hunt and the Dog Days
6.3 Tezcatlipoca: Night, Wind, and the Smoking Mirror
6.4 Xibalba: The Lords of the Underworld and the Hero Twins
6.5 Perseus and the Gorgon: The Trophy That Turns Away
6.6 Actaeon: The Hunter Turned
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6.8 Valhalla and Heorot: The Chosen Slain
6.9 Nimrod, Leviathan, and the Master of Animals
6.10 The Hidden Ones: Krypteia, the Black Hunter, and the Exposed Child
6.11 Gods from the Sky: The Ancient-Astronaut Temptation

The Predator is not a new monster but an old one recomposed. For Claude Lévi-Strauss a myth consists of all its variants, and the franchise belongs to a transformational group that includes the Wild Hunt, Achilles under the dog star, Tezcatlipoca, the Lords of Xibalba, Perseus and the Gorgon, Actaeon, Gilgamesh, the Valkyries' hall, Nimrod, the Spartan *krypteia*, and the exposed child who returns. Each homology clarifies one of the four turns of *trepein* that Chapter Nine systematizes: the solstitial turning of the sun, the turn of the rout, the turning of trophy into *apotropaion*, and the turn of perspective. Together they show what the franchise does to its sources. In myth, gods and monsters hunt, and demigods slay monsters. In the franchise, the hero is the prey.

6.1 The Films' Own Mythographers

The films stage their own mythography. Every human community the hunter visits names it in its own idiom. Anna's people tell of a demon that kills men and takes trophies in the hot season[1]. King Willie, the Jamaican gang leader of *Predator 2*, is a practitioner of vodou who believes the killer supernatural and prepares himself for battle against it[2]. In *AVP*, the hieroglyphs of the buried pyramid record that the hunters were worshipped as gods[3]. In *Prey*, Naru reads the lights of the descending ship as a Thunderbird and a sign that she is ready to hunt, and she names the creature *Mupitsi*, after a monstrous owl of Comanche folklore[8]. In *Killer of Killers*, the Viking Ursa names the warlord of the arena after the monster of her own epic[12].

Lévi-Strauss wrote, in the overture to *The Raw and the Cooked* (1964), that he sought to show not how men think in myths but how myths operate in men's minds without their being aware of it. The franchise dramatizes the proposition. Its alien has no single myth; it has as many as there are peoples it hunts, and each name is accurate within its own code, as the perspectivism of Chapter Two would predict. The comparative mythographer reads those names as variants of one structure, and the remainder of this chapter does so.

6.2 The Solstitial Hunt: The Wild Hunt and the Dog Days

The Greek word for solstice is a turning. Hesiod's *Works and Days* dates the farmer's labors by the *tropai ēelioio*, the "turnings of the sun" (ll. 479, 564, 663), and the tropics take their name from the same root. The hunts of myth ride at these turnings. Jacob Grimm's *Deutsche Mythologie* (1835) assembled the European traditions of the Wild Hunt, the "furious host" led by Wodan that storms across the sky above all in the Twelve Nights around the winter solstice; to see it portends death. German legends tell of the peasant who joins the huntsman's cry and finds next morning a haunch of the quarry hung at his door, with the injunction that whoever helped to hunt must also help to eat. The Wild Hunt gives a share of its kill to the one who answers its call, as the hunters of *Predator 2* give a pistol to the man who answered theirs.

The Predator rides at the other turning. Its season is the hottest of the year, and Greek poetry had already assigned that season to a hunter's star. In *Iliad* 22 (ll. 26–31), Achilles races toward Troy gleaming like the star of late summer that men call Orion's Dog, the brightest of stars but an evil sign that brings fever to wretched mortals; Hesiod's Sirius parches head and knees in the summer drought (*Works and Days* 587), and Rome named the hottest weeks the *dies caniculares*, the days of the little dog. Orion himself, in the versions preserved by Eratosthenes and Hyginus, was a giant hunter who boasted that he would kill every beast on earth and was slain by a scorpion that Earth sent against him. What follows in *Iliad* 22 is the epic prototype of the hunt of a man. Hector turns and flees (the *tropē* in its literal sense), Achilles pursues him three times around the walls like a hound after a fawn, and the victor strips the armor from the body and drags it behind his chariot. The Predator's "hottest years" are the dog days of the hunter's star, and its first literary ancestor is Achilles under Sirius.

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6.3 Tezcatlipoca: Night, Wind, and the Smoking Mirror

Of all the gods of the Americas, the closest homologue of the Predator is the Nahua Tezcatlipoca, "Smoking Mirror." His epithets describe the hunter almost clause by clause. As *Yohualli Ehecatl*, "Night, Wind," he is invisible and impalpable. As *Titlacauan*, "We Are His Slaves," he is sovereign over human fate. As *Necoc Yaotl*, "Enemy on Both Sides," he sows war among all parties at once, as the hunter of *Predator 2* kills gangsters and police alike. He takes the form of the jaguar; he is patron of warriors, sorcerers, and kings; and in his obsidian mirror, which smokes, he sees what is done in darkness. Guilhem Olivier's monograph *Moqueries et métamorphoses d'un dieu aztèque* (1997) emphasizes his mockery and his shape-shifting, and the dying Predator's laughter belongs to the same register. The hunter's cloak is the Night Wind; its visor, a dark glass that renders the night as smoky heat, is the smoking mirror; its trophy wall is a *tzompantli*, the skull rack that Spanish chroniclers described at Tenochtitlan and that archaeologists have excavated beside the Templo Mayor.

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The Florentine Codex compiled under Bernardino de Sahagún (Book 2) describes the festival of Toxcatl, held at the close of the dry season. A captive chosen for the perfection of his body lived for a year as the god's living image (*ixiptla*): he was honored, dressed in the god's finery, taught to play the flute, and in his last days given four wives; at the festival he climbed the temple, breaking his flutes on the steps, and was sacrificed. The rite is a predation that first familiarizes its victim, honoring the captive as the god before killing him, and it is the Mesoamerican counterpart of the Ainu bear rite discussed in Chapter Four. The franchise's Mesoamerican sediment is not accidental. Part of *Predator* was shot at Palenque; the pyramid of *AVP* drew on Aztec mythology[3]; and *Predators* (2010) identifies the site of the 1987 hunt as Guatemala[6], the homeland of the Popol Vuh.

6.4 Xibalba: The Lords of the Underworld and the Hero Twins

The K'iche' Maya Popol Vuh, in Dennis Tedlock's translation (1985), contains the most complete mythic template of the franchise. The Lords of Xibalba, One Death and Seven Death, summon the brothers One Hunahpu and Seven Hunahpu to the underworld to play ball, test them in a series of houses, defeat and kill them, and hang One Hunahpu's head in a calabash tree, where it becomes indistinguishable from the tree's fruit. The head spits into the palm of a Xibalban maiden, Blood Moon, who conceives the twins Hunahpu and Xbalanque. The twins descend in their turn and survive the Razor House, the Cold House, the Jaguar House, and the Fire House by cunning; in the Bat House, Hunahpu's head is cut off by a bat and taken by the Lords for a ball, and is recovered by a trick. At last the twins allow themselves to be burned, their bones ground and cast into the river. They are reborn, return disguised as vagabond performers who sacrifice and revive each other, and accept the Lords' request to be sacrificed in turn, after which they do not revive them. The twins then rise into the sky as the sun and the moon.

Every operation of the franchise is here. The Lords hunt by rules, and their houses are magic circles (Chapter Three). They hang the defeated hero's head in a tree, a *tropaion* (Chapter Four). The prey defeat them by simulating death and by disguise, the Outis gambit of Chapter Two. In *Prey*, the wounded Raphael lies still beneath the hunter, his heat lowered by Naru's herbs, and the hunter does not see him[8]. And the hunters perish by their own game. The Lords ask to undergo the sacrifice they had imposed, as the hunter of *Prey* is killed when its mask guides its own projectile back into it[8]. Two further features anticipate the franchise's third phase. The trophy-head in the tree is generative: it fathers its avengers, so that the trophy becomes kin. And the victorious prey become the sources of heat and light, the sun and the moon. The thermotropic sovereign is finally dethroned by the prey who become the sun.

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6.5 Perseus and the Gorgon: The Trophy That Turns Away

Perseus goes to the Gorgons equipped by the gods: winged sandals, the *kibisis* (a bag for the head), the curved sword called *harpē*, a polished shield, and the cap of Hades that makes its wearer invisible. The cap's Greek name, *kuneē* (*Iliad* 5.845), means a dog-skin cap; the helmet of invisibility is etymologically a hunter's hound-hide, and the cynegetic root returns. Jean-Pierre Vernant's *La Mort dans les yeux* (1985) reads the Gorgon as the face of radical otherness, a mask whose gaze petrifies, so that to see her is to be seen and to become her. Freud's fragment "Medusa's Head" (1922) read the severed head as the image of castration and its display as apotropaic. Athena set the head on her aegis, and the *gorgoneion* thereafter guarded shields, doors, and temple pediments. The trophy became an *apotropaion*, a device that turns evil away. *Tropaion* and *apotropaion* are cognate. The trophy commemorates a past turning; the apotropaic sign attempts to turn the future.

The franchise divides Perseus between its parties. The hunter has the cap of invisibility and the bag of heads. The prey inherits the shield. Perseus's polished bronze allowed the Gorgon's gaze to be returned without being suffered, and Naru, having observed that the hunter's projectiles are aimed by its mask, turns that targeting back upon its owner[8]. She then severs the head and carries it home. Her brother's rite of passage had ended with the head of a mountain lion[10]; hers ends with the head of the hunter. The *gorgoneion* protects only for a season. *Prey*'s credits end with three hunters' ships descending toward the camp[8]. The apotropaic turns evil away, and the turning resumes.

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6.6 Actaeon: The Hunter Turned

In the third book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, the hunter Actaeon stumbles upon Diana bathing; she changes him into a stag, and his own hounds, whose names Ovid catalogues, tear him apart without recognizing their master. Giordano Bruno's *De gli eroici furori* (1585) made the myth an allegory of contemplation. Actaeon is the intellect in pursuit of divine beauty; beholding it, he is converted into what he hunted and devoured by his own thoughts, and the hunter becomes the prey as the knower becomes the known. The franchise is an Actaeon cycle. Its elite hunters of men become prey at the moment they glimpse what was hidden: the shimmer of the cloak is the bathing goddess, and the sight is fatal. *Badlands* completes the cycle by turning the Yautja himself into quarry; reviewers noted Dek's reversed role as prey on Genna[14]. Bruno's reading, metamorphosis as illumination, anticipates the third phase, in which Dek's transformation from killer to protector is an Actaeon metamorphosis read as conversion. The franchise even supplies a comic coda for Actaeon's hounds. In *The Predator* (2018), one of the hunters' alien hounds, shot through the head, becomes a docile dog that plays fetch[7]. Ovid's hounds turned on their master; the franchise's hounds turn into pets.

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6.7 Gilgamesh: The Expedition for a Name

The Standard Babylonian epic of Gilgamesh, in Andrew George's translation (1999), opens with a king without equal who oppresses his city until the gods create a rival for him. Enkidu begins as a wild man who lives among the herds, fills the trapper's pits, and tears up his snares, freeing the game. Drawn into human society, he meets Gilgamesh in a doorway, and the two wrestle until the contest ends in friendship. Together they travel to the Cedar Forest to kill its guardian Humbaba, wrapped in seven terrifying radiances, and they undertake the expedition, Gilgamesh declares, to establish a name that will endure. They kill the guardian, fell the cedars, and pay for it with Enkidu's death, which sends Gilgamesh in search of a life that will not end.

The epic contains the franchise's dialectic in miniature. The expedition for a name is the prestige hunt of Chapter Three. The gods' creation of an equal answers the predicament of a hunter who has no worthy opponent. Enkidu the trap-breaker is the first enemy of the apparatus of capture, a being who frees game from snares as Naru frees herself from the trappers. And the wrestling match that ends in friendship is the passage from agon to kinship that the franchise completes four millennia later. Hunt, recognition, kinship, and

mourning: the oldest surviving epic follows the same sequence.

6.8 Valhalla and Heorot: The Chosen Slain

Snorri Sturluson's *Gylfaginning* and the Eddic *Grímnismál* describe Valhalla, Odin's hall, where the *einherjar*, warriors chosen from the slain by the Valkyries (*valkyrja*, "chooser of the slain"), fight one another every day, are restored every evening, feast, and wait for the last battle. In later folklore the same Odin leads the Wild Hunt, so that the Norse god unites the two functions the franchise assigns to its hunters: the hunter who rides at the solstice and the collector of champions. *Killer of Killers* realizes the second function with precision. Its warlord keeps in suspended animation the warriors who have killed Yautja, releases them into an arena, and seeks among them the most powerful being in the galaxy; the closing vault holds Ursa beside Naru and, in the extended cut released in July 2025, Dutch and Harrigan[12]. Cryostasis is the *einherjar*'s nightly restoration, and the arena is Valhalla's daily battle. The Viking warrior is carried at last not to Odin's hall but to an alien warlord's, and Valhalla is revealed as an apparatus of capture. The vault is also the franchise's own pantheon, assembling its heroes for future combat, which Chapter Nine treats as an effect of franchise logic as well as of myth.

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The Anglo-Saxon hall supplies the counter-image. Grendel is a *mearcstapa*, a walker of the borders (*Beowulf* 103), of the kin of Cain, excluded from the joy of Heorot, and his mother's vengeance turns his death into a blood feud. *Predators* gives the Yautja a feud of their own between larger and smaller kinds[6], and Ursa's name for the warlord, the Grendel King, places the alien in the border-walker's line. The hunter is at once Odin and Grendel, the lord of the chosen slain and the outcast who raids the hall.

6.9 Nimrod, Leviathan, and the Master of Animals

Genesis calls Nimrod "a mighty hunter before the LORD" (10:9), the first of this dissertation's epigraphs. Later exegesis darkened him. Josephus (*Antiquities* 1.4.2) made him the tyrant who incited the building of Babel, and Augustine (*City of God* 16.4) read "before the Lord" as "against the Lord." A long tradition made him the first king and the archetypal hunter of men, as if sovereignty were born from the manhunt. (That the director of *Predators* is named Nimród is a coincidence the mythographer may record but not interpret.) The Book of Job answers the hunter-king. From the whirlwind God displays Behemoth and Leviathan and asks whether the human can draw out Leviathan with a hook (41:1); Leviathan is king over all the children of pride (41:34). Hobbes named the commonwealth after this uncapturable beast. The apparatus of capture of Chapter Five is Hobbes's Leviathan attempting Job's impossibility, and the hunter's self-destruct is Job's answer: there is a creature that cannot be drawn out with a hook.

The hunter also inherits the office of the Master of Animals, the figure who rules and protects the game: the *Potnia Thērōn* of archaic Greek art, and the "masters" or "owners" of animal kinds in Amazonian cosmologies, whom Carlos Fausto analyzes as at once predators and protectors, owners who adopt as well as kill. The Yautja breed their quarry, as the queen kept beneath the Antarctic pyramid of *AVP* shows, and they stock their preserves. Mastery in Fausto's sense is double, and the franchise's third phase activates its second side, the master who protects what he could have killed.

6.10 The Hidden Ones: Krypteia, the Black Hunter, and the Exposed Child

Pierre Vidal-Naquet's "The Black Hunter and the Origin of the Athenian Ephebeia" (1968) showed that the Athenian ephebe, the youth on the threshold of citizenship, was associated with hunting by night, at the frontier, with nets and cunning. This was the despised technique of Plato's *Laws*, opposed to the daylight combat of the hoplite. Its mythic charter was Melanthos, "the black one," who won a border duel by deceit. The Yautja initiate is an ephebe in this sense: the young hunters of *AVP* undertake their rite of passage at the edge of the world[3], and Dek's first hunt takes him to the edge of the galaxy.

Sparta institutionalized the black hunt. Plutarch's *Life of Lycurgus* (28) describes the *krypteia*: young Spartiates sent into the countryside with daggers and bare provisions, hiding by day and killing by night the helots they found.

Citing Aristotle, Plutarch adds that the ephors, on entering office, formally declared war on the helots, so that killing them would bring no pollution. The *krypteia*, from *kryptein*, "to hide," is the most exact historical homologue of the cloaked initiatory hunter, and the ephors' annual declaration is the most exact legal model of the *justa praeda*: lawful prey created by decree. The difference is decisive. The *krypteia* hunted a subjugated and disarmed population, which is precisely what the Yautja code forbids. The code is the *krypteia* reformed by Plato's demand for sacred hunting.

Sparta also exposed its weak infants at the Apothetae (*Lycurgus* 16), and *Badlands* tells the story of an exposed child who returns. Otto Rank's *The Myth of the Birth of the Hero* (1909) abstracted the pattern from Sargon, Moses, Oedipus, Romulus, and others: a child of high birth is condemned and exposed, rescued by animals or humble people, returns to confront and defeat his father, and attains his rank. Dek is condemned by his father as too weak, carried to the death planet by his brother's sacrifice, sheltered by a damaged synthetic and an alien juvenile, and returns to defeat his father, refuse his father's offer, and found his own clan[14]. Romulus, exposed and suckled by a she-wolf, founded Rome and was the first to dedicate the *spolia opima*; Dek, whose ethics are corrected by a lesson about wolves, returns with a skull and founds a clan of kin. Oedipus, exposed, returned and killed his father; in *Badlands* the father dies in the jaws of the adopted child Bud, a parricide displaced onto kin by adoption, to which Chapter Eight returns.

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6.11 Gods from the Sky: The Ancient-Astronaut Temptation

Once the franchise yielded to a mythology that degraded its sources. Paul W. S. Anderson drew *AVP* from Aztec mythology, the crossover comics, and the writings of Erich von Däniken. In the film, the pyramid's carvings mix Egyptian, Cambodian, and Aztec motifs; its hieroglyphs reveal that the hunters taught early humans to build pyramids, were worshipped as gods, returned once a century to use human hosts in their rite of passage, and annihilated whole civilizations with their self-destruct devices when overwhelmed, Anderson's explanation for cultures that seemed to vanish[3]. The ancient-astronaut hypothesis is, as the same source notes, long debunked and founded on misreadings of Aztec myth[3]. Archaeologists have long objected that it denies the peoples of Mesoamerica, Egypt, and Southeast Asia authorship of their own monuments. It is colonial erasure in mythic form, and the reverse of Lévi-Strauss's project: where structural anthropology treated myth as thought, von Däniken treated it as the misremembered record of contact with superior beings.

The franchise's third phase corrects the error. In *Prey*, Naru names the hunter in her own language, defeats it with her own knowledge of plants and terrain, and the credits retell her victory in painted images in the manner of Plains pictorial art[8]. The people record their own myth. In *Killer of Killers*, a Viking, a shinobi, and a Latino Navy pilot each defeat a hunter with the techniques of their own world[12]. Myth returns to the mythmakers.

The homologies can now be stated as a single transformational group.

Myth or rite	Principal source	Hunter figure	Shared operation	Franchise realization
Wild Hunt	Grimm, *Deutsche Mythologie* (1835)	Wodan and the furious host	Solstitial ride; a share of the kill for whoever answers the cry	Seasonal arrival; the pistol given to Harrigan
Orion's Dog	*Iliad* 22; Hesiod, *Works and Days*	Achilles under Sirius	Hunt in the hot season; pursuit of the man who turns; spoils	"The hottest years"; the rout; the stripped body
Toxcatl	Sahagún, Florentine Codex, Book 2	Tezcatlipoca, Smoking Mirror	Invisibility; dark mirror; honored victim; skull rack	Cloak; thermal visor; trophy wall
Xibalba	Popol Vuh, trans. Tedlock (1985)	One Death and Seven Death	Trials by rule; head hung in a tree; victory by feigned death	The code's trials; flayed *tropaion*; mud and herb
Gorgon	Hesiod, Pindar, Ovid; Vernant (1985)	Perseus with the cap of Hades	Invisibility; returned gaze; head in a bag; *gorgoneion*	Cloak; laser turned back; Naru's trophy head
Actaeon	Ovid, *Met.* 3; Bruno (1585)	The hunter who sees	Metamorphosis of hunter into prey	Commandos hunted; Dek on Genna
Cedar Forest	*Gilgamesh*, trans. George (1999)	Gilgamesh and Enkidu	Expedition for a name; equal created; wrestling into friendship	Prestige hunt; the worthy opponent; kinship

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Myth or rite	Principal source	Hunter figure	Shared operation	Franchise realization
Valhalla	Snorri, *Gylfaginning*; *Grímnismál*	Odin and the Valkyries	The chosen slain stored for future battle	The cryogenic vault of *Killer of Killers*
Krypteia	Plutarch, *Lycurgus* 28	The hidden young men	Invisible initiatory manhunt; prey made lawful by decree	Cloaked rite of passage; *justa praeda*
Exposed hero	Rank (1909); Plutarch, *Lycurgus* 16	The condemned child	Exposure, rescue, return, defeat of the father	Dek's exile and return

Read down its last column, the table restates the franchise. Read across its rows, it records a single systematic transformation: in every source the hunter is divine, royal, or monstrous, and the hero who escapes or defeats him is a demigod. The franchise grants the heroic function to the prey, an unremarkable human body, or a runt, armed with cunning, mud, a medicinal herb, and the knowledge of its own world. Chapter Seven turns from ancient myth to the modern myth that inherited its monsters, the literature and cinema of horror.

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VII

Chapter Seven

The Predator in the Bestiary of Horror

7.1 The Interstitial Hunter
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The franchise was conceived as a hybrid. Schwarzenegger recalled that he liked the idea of beginning as an action-adventure and then bringing in horror and science fiction[1], and Gene Siskel dismissed the result as a stale mixture of *Rambo* and *Alien*[1]. The horror it produced is of a distinct kind. The franchise's human is not eaten, impregnated, possessed, punished, annihilated, or ignored. It is *selected*. This chapter names that experience **elective horror** and situates it within the theory of horror (Noël Carroll, Mary Douglas, Robin Wood, René Girard, Barbara Creed, Carol Clover, H. P. Lovecraft, Eugene Thacker, Burke, and Kant) and within horror's adjacent genres: the fiction of reverse colonization, the manhunt film, the slasher, and the game.

7.1 The Interstitial Hunter

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Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990) defines art-horror by a monster that is both threatening and impure, and locates impurity in categorical interstitiality: the monster fuses or splits categories that culture keeps apart. The Predator is interstitial on three axes at once. It is animal and machine, a body of mandibles and dreadlocks wearing a plasma caster; it is humanoid and arthropod, its mandibles reportedly suggested by James Cameron[1]; and it is visible and invisible. Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985), published two years before the film, identified three boundary breakdowns in late-twentieth-century culture: between human and animal, between organism and machine, and between the physical and the non-physical. The Predator is the monstrous twin of Haraway's cyborg, the figure in which all three collapse.

Carroll also proposed that the paradox of horror, our pleasure in what disgusts and frightens us, is resolved by curiosity: the impure monster fascinates because it defies categories, and the narrative pleasure of horror lies in disclosure. His "complex discovery plot" moves through onset, discovery, confirmation, and confrontation, and *Predator* follows it exactly: the skinned Green Berets (onset), Billy's intuition and Anna's legend (discovery), the shimmer that Mac glimpses and the blood on the leaves (confirmation), and the duel (confrontation). The theory also explains the franchise's economy. Every sequel discloses more: the ship's interior in *Predator 2*, whose makers set out to expand the creature's origins and motives[2], the hunters' homeworld and language in *Badlands*. Curiosity is the franchise's engine, and disclosure is its risk. When *Badlands* made a Yautja its sympathetic protagonist, Peter Bradshaw complained that the creature, humanized, "ceases to be the Predator"[14]. Carroll would have recognized the complaint: a fully disclosed monster is no longer

interstitial.

7.2 Matter out of Place: The Salvation of Dirt

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place: pollution is the by-product of classification, and the anomalous, whatever falls between categories, is the dangerous. The franchise inverts the relation between purity and danger. Its hero survives by becoming dirt. Dutch, plastered with mud, is matter out of place on a human body, and the anomaly removes him from the classificatory order of the hunter's sensorium; what cannot be classified cannot be hunted. The hunter, for its part, is betrayed by its own anomalous fluid. Its blood is luminous and green, the wrong color in the wrong place, and the blood on the leaves makes the invisible visible. Kristeva's abject (Chapter Four) here changes sides: the polluting substance saves the prey and exposes the predator.

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7.3 The Return of the Repressed

Robin Wood's "An Introduction to the American Horror Film" (1979), expanded in *Hollywood from Vietnam to Reagan* (1986), reduced the genre to a formula, normality threatened by the monster, and read the monster as the return of what a culture represses: its Others, among them women, the proletariat, other cultures, ethnic groups, alternative sexualities, and children. Wood distinguished progressive horror, which sides with the monster against an oppressive normality, from reactionary horror, which restores normality, and he judged most Reagan-era horror reactionary.

Predator is both, and the dissertation's earlier chapters identify what returns in it. On one level the repressed is the prey-memory of the species, the knowledge that the hunter was once hunted (Chapter One). On another it is America's own practice of hunting others: the trophies of Vietnam, the covert wars of Central America, the hanging tree (Chapter Four). The Other returns as the self's own practice, wearing an alien face. *Predator 2* makes the ambivalence acute. Its city of Black and Latino gangs reproduces the racial anxieties of its moment, and Roger Ebert discerned subliminal racial coding in its creature[2]; yet the same film turns its hunter's violence equally upon the police and the state. The franchise is reactionary in its spectacle and progressive in its dismantling of the hard body, and Wood's categories describe a tension within each film rather than a verdict upon it.

7.4 The Monstrous Double

René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) describes the sacrificial crisis as the collapse of differences: rivals locked in mimetic violence come to resemble one another until each perceives the other as a "monstrous double," and the crisis resolves only when the community discharges its violence upon a surrogate victim, whose death founds the sacred. The final duel of *Predator* is a sacrificial crisis staged as single combat. Dutch makes himself the hunter's double. He covers himself in mud, arms himself with bow and spear, and gives a war cry to call the hunter to him[1]. The hunter makes itself Dutch's double, setting aside mask and weapons to fight hand to hand. When each finally asks the other the same question, "What the hell are you?," the differences have collapsed entirely. The self-destruct then completes the Girardian sequence with an inversion: the double expels itself, becoming its own surrogate victim, and the survivor walks out of the fire as one who has touched the sacred. The franchise's third phase draws the consequence Girard's theory resists. The doubles become kin rather than rivals.

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7.5 Two Monstrous Economies: Creed, the Alien, and the Predalien

Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) read *Alien* as a horror of the archaic mother: the ship as womb, the egg chamber, the impregnation of the male body, the birth that kills. Its horror is reproductive. The Predator's horror is tropaic, and the crossovers stage the encounter of the two economies with precision. In *AVP* the hunters parasitize the reproductive horror, keeping a captive queen and using human bodies as hosts to breed the quarry for their initiates[3]. In *Aliens vs. Predator: Requiem* the hybrid born of a hunter's body, the Predalien, implants its young in pregnant women in Gunnison's hospital[4]. This is the exact inversion of the code's tenderest exemption, the sparing of the pregnant Leona[2]. The hybrid of the two monsters violates the ethic of the one by the biology of the other.

Creed's analysis also illuminates the unmasking. The hunter's face, a mouth ringed by four mandibles that open outward, invites her reading of the *vagina dentata*, and Dutch's obscene epithet at the sight lends the reading support. The scene repeats the structure that Freud found in the Medusa's head (Chapter Six): a revelation of the face that terrifies, followed by a verbal gesture that wards it off. The franchise's monster is coded with aggressive masculinity in its weapons and its hunt, and with the monstrous-feminine in its face. Its interstitiality extends to gender.

7.6 The Final Girl and the Final Hunter

Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) identified the slasher's Final Girl: watchful, resourceful, sexually reluctant, often boyishly named, she survives the killer, appropriates his weapon, and carries the predominantly male audience's identification across the line of gender. The franchise's surviving women trace the Final Girl's evolution across its three phases. Anna is spared because unarmed, a non-player. Leona is spared because pregnant, an exempted body. Alexa Woods is marked by the hunter and allied with it, the first woman the code recognizes[3]. Naru, the healer who wants to hunt, wins by observation, Clover's investigating gaze, and by appropriating the hunter's own targeting system[8]. Ursa begins where Final Girls end, as a warrior with a war band. Thia, the synthetic cut in half, survives as a torso and becomes the hunter's sister in arms. The arc runs from the woman who survives by not playing to the woman who wins by seeing, and in the third phase it becomes a starting point rather than an ending.

Clover also analyzed the slasher's "I-camera," the point-of-view shot that aligns the spectator with the unseen killer. The thermal point of view is the I-camera given a different *Umwelt*. The genealogy is direct: Stephen Hopkins came to *Predator 2* from *A Nightmare on Elm Street 5*[2]. Clover argued that the slasher's identification with the killer was unstable and passed to the Final Girl. The franchise follows the opposite path to its end. *Badlands* gives the killer the whole narrative, and one reviewer likened it to a *Terminator 2* told entirely from the cyborg's point of view[14]. The I-camera has become the protagonist.

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7.7 Against Cosmic Indifference: Elective Horror

H. P. Lovecraft's "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1927) grounded the genre in fear of the unknown, and his fiction made that fear cosmic: the horror of a universe in which humanity is negligible, its values parochial and its existence unnoticed. *AVP* took inspiration from *At the Mountains of Madness*[3], but the franchise's horror is the antithesis of Lovecraft's. It is not the horror of insignificance but the horror of significance. Something out there is interested in us, too interested: it studies our weapons, scans our wombs, learns our voices, and keeps our skulls. This is elective horror, the dread of being chosen by a being that values you according to a scale you did not make. Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011) distinguishes the world-for-us, the ◀ VII world-in-itself, and the world-without-us, and finds the last to be horror's proper object. The thermal gaze discloses a fourth: the world-for-them, a world fully meaningful to another subject in which we figure as game. *Badlands* makes the world-for-them the film's own frame.

The experience has the structure of the sublime, with one decisive difference. Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) made terror the ruling principle of the sublime and named its sources: obscurity, power, and privations such as darkness, solitude, and silence. The cloaked hunter in the canopy combines all three. Kant's *Critique of Judgment* (1790) resolved the dynamically sublime, nature as a might that has no dominion over us, by the subject's discovery, from a position of safety, of its own rational superiority to nature. The franchise denies its prey that safety and that resolution. Dutch does not rise above the might that threatens him by reason; he sinks beneath it into the mud. Call it the telluric sublime: a mastery of terror achieved by abasement. Only the spectator, safe in the theater, enjoys the Kantian version.

7.8 Reverse Colonization and the Manhunt

H. G. Wells's *The War of the Worlds* (1898) asks its readers, before judging the Martians, to remember the extermination of the Tasmanians by European settlers within fifty years. Stephen Arata's "The Occidental Tourist" (1990) read *Dracula* and its contemporaries as fictions of reverse colonization, in which the imperial center imagines itself invaded by the forces it had unleashed abroad. The franchise belongs to this tradition with a qualification. The Predator does not colonize: it neither occupies nor settles (the speculation in *The Predator* about a future colonization of a warmed Earth is the exception that proves the rule). What it reverses is not the colony but the safari. The jungle hunt of the Western sportsman, mounted in Akeley's dioramas (Chapter Four), returns with the sportsman as the game.

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The manhunt film runs parallel. Its lineage descends from Connell through *The Most Dangerous Game* (1932) and *The Naked Prey* (1965) to *Hard Target* (1993), *Surviving the Game* (1994), *Battle Royale* (2000), *The Hunger Games* (2012), and *The Hunt* (2020), while Mel Gibson's *Apocalypto* (2006) restages the jungle chase and the leap from a waterfall among the Maya. In these films the hunters are human, and the horror is social: of class, race, spectacle, and the state. In the franchise the hunter is another species, and the horror is ontological. The year 1987 brackets the alternative. In June Schwarzenegger was hunted by an alien in *Predator*, and in November he was hunted on state television in *The Running Man*, with Jesse Ventura in both films[1]. The televised manhunt is the apparatus of capture as entertainment (Chapter Five). The alien hunt is the war machine with a code.

7.9 Ludic Completion

The franchise's last genre is the game. Rebellion's *Aliens versus Predator* (1999) gave each species its own campaign, and Illfonic's *Predator: Hunting Grounds* (2020) set one player as the hunter against four as a fireteam; Schwarzenegger reprised Dutch for the game as downloadable content[1]. The asymmetric game realizes what the films could only depict. Huizinga's magic circle becomes literal; Caillois's fusion of *agôn* and mimicry becomes a protocol; and, most significantly, the player may occupy either position. The franchise's deixis becomes playable: the "you" of "What the hell are you?" is assigned at the lobby screen. Elective horror becomes elective in the ordinary sense. The player chooses to be hunted.

The argument of the chapter can be summarized as a bestiary of horror's regimes, distinguished by what each monster makes of the human.

Regime	Exemplary monsters	What the human becomes	Characteristic fear	Relation to the franchise
Cosmic	Lovecraft's Old Ones (*At the Mountains of Madness*, 1936)	Negligible	Insignificance	*AVP* borrows its Antarctic premise; the franchise inverts its indifference
Alimentary	*Jaws* (1975); Plumwood's crocodile	Food	Being eaten	The Kalisk eats; the Predator never does
Reproductive	*Alien* (1979)	Host	Being impregnated	The crossovers; the Predalien
Possessive	*The Exorcist* (1973)	Vessel	Losing the self	Ventriloquial predation takes only the voice
Punitive	*Halloween* (1978); *A Nightmare on Elm Street* (1984)	Transgressor	Being punished	The thermal I-camera; Hopkins's *Predator 2*
Annihilative	Wells's Martians (1898); *Godzilla* (1954)	Obstacle	Extinction	The nuclear strike of *Requiem*
Elective	The Predator	Worthy prey	Being chosen	The franchise's own regime

Elective horror is the horror proper to a being that is valued. Its terror is inseparable from a flattery, and that ambivalence accounts both for the franchise's durability and for its eventual transformation. A monster that honors its prey can, under the right conditions, become kin to it. Chapter Eight follows those conditions film by film.

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Chapter Eight

The Dialectic of the Franchise, 1987–2025

8.1 Phase I: Disqualification
8.2 Phase II: Capture
8.3 Phase III: Kinship
8.4 The Dialectic Stated

Read diachronically, the nine films form a dialectic in three moments: predation as *disqualification* (1987–1990), predation *captured* by state, corporation, and market (2004–2018), and predation as the ground of *kinship* (2022–2025). Each phase has a characteristic relation between hunter and prey, a characteristic role for the apparatus of capture, a characteristic trophy, and a characteristic point of view. Each also answers the founding question, "What the hell are you?," in its own way.

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Phase	Films	Hunter and prey	The apparatus	The trophy	Point of view	The deictic question
I. Disqualification (1987–1990)	*Predator*; *Predator 2*	Agon under a code; the unarmed exempt	Betrays the prey	Field *tropaion* and skull; denied the victor, then given as gift	The prey's, with thermal inserts	Asked and returned
II. Capture (2004–2018)	*AVP*; *Requiem*; *Predators*; *The Predator*	Hunt organized as husbandry, preserve, and harvest	Seizes body, weapon, and genome	Specimen	Divided among factions	Cut off unanswered
III. Kinship (2022–2025)	*Prey*; *Killer of Killers*; *Badlands*	Alliance and adoption across species	Opposed by hunter and prey together	Token of passage	The prey turned hunter; then the hunter's own	Answered in the first person

8.1 Phase I: Disqualification

Predator (1987). The screenplay's founding conception, a hunter in pursuit of the most dangerous species and of its "most dangerous man"[1], organizes the film's argument. It takes the hard body of Reaganite cinema to the edge of the species and dismantles it. The unit's firepower is spent on an empty jungle; its members die one by one; the leader survives by surrendering his body's identity to the mud. The phase's relations are all present. The hunter disqualifies, sparing the unarmed Anna. The apparatus betrays, in Dillon's deception and his "expendable asset." And the prey survives by dirt, cunning, and reversal. The hunter has no name. Anna's people call it a demon that takes trophies in the hot season[1]; the title calls it by a generic noun. Defeated, it denies Dutch his trophy by spending itself in fire.

The franchise later revised this film from its third phase. According to the actor Bennett Taylor, the screenplay of *Prey* identifies Billy, the 1987 unit's Native tracker, as a reincarnation of Naru's brother Taabe, so that Billy's solitary stand on the log bridge becomes the return of a memory from a past life[8].

Whatever its status in canon, the revision is diagnostic. In its third phase the franchise rewrites its first as genealogy: the stand that Chapter Two read as a trope of the mystical native is reclaimed as a kinship that spans 268 years.

Predator 2 (1990). The Thomases moved the hunt into what they pitched as an "urban jungle": a Los Angeles of 1997 gripped by heat wave and by war between Colombian and Jamaican cartels[2]. The film's politics are double. Its protagonist, Danny Glover's Harrigan, made the franchise's hero a Black police lieutenant, and Glover counted the role among the few in which he felt larger than life[2]. Its city, however, reproduces the period's racialized imagery of the gang, and its creature drew Ebert's charge of subliminal racial coding[2]. The code is displayed more fully than in 1987: the duel with King Willie, the sparing of the pregnant Leona, the impartial slaughter of armed passengers. So is the apparatus. Keyes's federal task force, insulated against heat, waits for the hunter in a slaughterhouse in order to capture it for study, and dies there[2].

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The film's last movement completes the first phase. Harrigan interrupts the self-destruct, kills the hunter with its own disc inside its ship, and finds himself among the clan's elders, who give him the Adolini pistol; he anticipates their return[2]. Disqualification ends in recognition. The film's paratext anticipates the third phase. Simon Hawke's novelization tells much of the story from the hunter's point of view, including its humiliation at being unmasked and its reason for sparing Leona[2]. The hunter's interiority first appears in print. It took thirty-five years to reach the screen.

8.2 Phase II: Capture

AVP (2004). The crossover inaugurates the second phase in content and in form. Its hunters have become husbandmen. They keep a captive queen beneath an Antarctic pyramid, bait humans with a heat bloom, and breed their initiates' quarry in human hosts[3]. The code persists in recognition, as when Scar marks Alexa Woods with the hunter's sign and the elder gives her a spear[3], but the hunt is now an organized economy. The film is also the moment at which the franchise itself was captured by a larger market. Pitting two studio-owned monsters against each other, it grossed $177.4 million worldwide[3], and James Cameron, before he saw it, likened the venture to *Frankenstein Meets the Wolf Man*: a studio playing its monster assets against one another[3]. The comparison is precise. The crossover is the franchise's apparatus of capture turned upon its own creatures.

Aliens vs. Predator: Requiem (2007). Every agent in the sequel erases. The lone hunter sent to clean up the Predalien outbreak works to remove the evidence of its kind[5]. The Predalien violates the code by implanting its young in pregnant women[4]. The state lures Gunnison's survivors to the town center with the promise of an airlift and destroys the town with a nuclear weapon, after which a colonel hands the hunter's pistol to Ms. Yutani[4]. The hunter's cleanup and the state's annihilation converge, and the only thing to survive both is the weapon, passed to capital.

Predators (2010). The third mainline film relocates the hunt to a preserve stocked with killers abducted from Earth's zones of exception, where two kinds of Yautja pursue a blood feud and a smaller hunter is held captive by larger ones[6]. Its title, the producers explained, refers both to the hunters and to the human killers who are their game[6]. Capture has become reciprocal and general. The hunters capture humans; one faction of hunters captures another; and on the preserve the humans prey on one another. Noland ambushes his guests for their gear, and the physician Edwin paralyzes his protector[6]. The film ends as the cycle resumes, with new prey parachuting into the jungle. The preserve has no outside.

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The Predator (2018). Shane Black's film takes the second phase to its terminus. Its hunters have become an apparatus: a larger, genetically enhanced hunter polices a renegade who has defected to bring humanity an armor designed to kill Yautja. The skull-and-spine trophy is reinterpreted as genetic harvest, and the government's laboratory frames the visits as a race to collect human genetic material before climate change ends the species[7]. The film also locates the next stage of human evolution in an autistic boy, Rory, whom the enhanced hunter seeks to abduct for his DNA[7]. The conceit reproduces what disability studies, from Eli Clare's *Exile and Pride* (1999) onward, has criticized as the "supercrip" narrative, in which disability is redeemed by an extraordinary compensatory gift. The apparatus of capture here extends to neurological difference, which becomes a resource to be harvested.

The film's treatment of the deictic question is its most revealing gesture. Its hero, Quinn McKenna, asks the dying enhanced hunter what it is, echoing Dutch, and kills it before it can answer[7]. In 1987 the question was returned. In 2018 it is cut off. The second phase ends in a refusal to hear the other speak. Its industrial fate confirms the impasse. In 2019 Disney acquired most of 21st Century Fox's film assets, the Predator franchise among them[2], and the new owner showed no intention of continuing the 2018 film's storylines[7]. The franchise was itself captured, and its next film went back three centuries.

8.3 Phase III: Kinship

Prey (2022). Dan Trachtenberg's film relocates the hunt to the Comanche Nation in 1719 and restructures the franchise around a single protagonist. Naru is a healer who wants to hunt. She reads the hunter's descent as a Thunderbird and a sign that she is ready, names the creature after a monster of Comanche folklore, and watches it climb the chain of predators from snake to wolf to bear to human beings[8]. The film distinguishes three economies of the hunt. The first is the Comanche rite of passage, in which her brother Taabe returns with the head of a mountain lion[10]. The second is the commodity hunt of the French trappers, who skin the bison and leave the meat to rot and who stake Naru and Taabe as bait[9]. The third is the tropaic hunt of the Yautja, which ignores the bound captives and kills their captors[8]. Naru defeats the hunter by synthesizing what she has observed. A medicinal plant lowers the heat of the wounded Raphael until the hunter cannot see him. The hunter's mask aims its weapons. A trapper can serve as bait. Her victory is a mētic reversal in the strictest sense: the mask guides the hunter's own projectile back into it. She severs its head, paints her face with its glowing blood, and returns to her people, whom she tells it is time to move[8].

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The film's production enacts part of its argument. *Prey* was released with a complete Comanche-language dub performed by its cast, the first feature film to offer one, and critics praised its Indigenous casting[8]. Michelle Raheja's *Reservation Reelism* (2010) calls the practice by which Indigenous people assert control over their own image *visual sovereignty*, and Grace Dillon's *Walking the Clouds* (2012) named the field of *Indigenous futurisms*. Neither concept applies to *Prey* without qualification, since its director and writer are not Native, but the film moves toward both. Its credits retell Naru's victory in painted images, ending with three ships descending toward her people[8]. The prey has become the author of her own record.

Predator: Killer of Killers (2025). The animated triptych makes kinship its explicit subject. Each segment begins in a family wound. Ursa, a Viking in Karelia in 841, avenges a father whom a rival chieftain had forced her to kill as a child, and loses her son to the hunter who follows. Kenji, in Japan in 1609, refused to fight his brother Kiyoshi for their father's succession and was scarred and exiled; the brothers reconcile only when a hunter attacks them both, and Kiyoshi dies. John Torres, a Latino mechanic who becomes a Navy pilot in 1942, outwits a hunter's fighter craft after his commander sacrifices himself[12]. In each case the hunter is the occasion on which enmity between kin is converted into alliance. The final segment generalizes the conversion. Abducted, collared, and ordered to fight one another in the Grendel King's arena, the three warriors, who

share no language, refuse and turn together upon their captor; Ursa sacrifices herself so that the others may escape[12]. Trachtenberg cited *Best in Show* as the structural model for a film designed to distribute empathy across all three protagonists[12]. The Yautja appear here as an apparatus of capture, and the human response is a kinship that crosses centuries and languages.

Predator: Badlands (2025). The franchise's ninth film completes the dialectic by making a Yautja its protagonist. Dek, a runt condemned by his father Njohrr, is carried to the death planet Genna by his brother Kwei, whom Njohrr then executes. There Dek allies with Thia, a damaged Weyland-Yutani synthetic, and with Bud, a juvenile creature who marks him with her saliva in gratitude for his protection. The mark proves decisive. When Dek attacks the Kalisk, the regenerating apex predator he came to kill, it defeats him and then spares him after smelling him: Bud is its child[14]. Learning from Thia that the alpha wolf is the one who protects the pack, Dek frees the Kalisk from the corporation that wants its regenerative power. Tessa, Thia's corporate "sister," kills the Kalisk from inside its body after it swallows her, and Dek kills Tessa. Returning to Yautja Prime, Dek presents Tessa's skull to his father as a trophy and demands his own cloak; when Njohrr refuses and orders his death, Dek defeats him. He refuses the father's belated offer of a place in the clan, having found his own clan with Thia and Bud, and the grown Bud bites off Njohrr's head. As a great Yautja ship appears on the horizon, Dek identifies it as his mother[14].

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Three frameworks converge on this ending. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) imagined the primal horde, in which the sons kill the father who monopolizes power, consume him, and found law upon their guilt. *Badlands* rewrites the myth. The father dies by the jaws of an adopted child of another species, no meal follows, and the death founds not guilt but a clan of chosen kin. Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) urged its readers to "make kin, not babies" and to cultivate "oddkin" across species; Dek's clan of a Yautja, a synthetic, and an alien juvenile is oddkin in Haraway's sense. Carlos Fausto's account of familiarizing predation in Amazonia, in which the captor adopts the captured and predation becomes the production of kin, describes the film's central mechanism: the hunter is spared because a child of the prey species has marked him as kin, and he in turn adopts that child. The franchise that began with a hunter that marks its prey as trophy ends with a prey that marks its hunter as family. Its final image displaces the patriarchal clan as well. The father's rule ends, and the mother arrives.

The film's commercial and critical reception registered the transformation. It was the first mainline installment, apart from *AVP*, to be rated PG-13, grossed

$184.6 million worldwide, and divided critics between those who welcomed a rooting interest in the hunter and those, like Peter Bradshaw, who held that a humanized Predator ceases to be one[14]. The objection is serious, and Chapter Nine takes it up.

8.4 The Dialectic Stated

The three phases can now be stated as a single movement. In the first, hunter and prey meet in an agon governed by a code, and the apparatus stands behind the prey and betrays it. The trophy is taken and, at the end, given. In the second, the apparatus seizes the hunt itself. The hunters become husbandmen and wardens, the state and the corporation capture weapon and genome, and the franchise is captured in turn by the market that recombines its monsters. The trophy becomes a specimen, and the deictic question is cut off before it can be answered. In the third, hunter and prey ally against capture, and predation becomes the production of kin. The trophy becomes a token of passage, the Final Girl becomes the hunter, and the hunter becomes the protagonist.

The deictic question traces the same arc. In 1987 “What the hell are you?” is asked by the prey and returned verbatim by the hunter: two beings meet as mirror images, each a “you” to the other. In 2018 it is asked and cut off: the apparatus’s champion kills the other before it can speak. In 2025 it is answered at last, and in the first person. The hunter speaks its own language, and the franchise’s final line of dialogue is a possessive. Dek names the approaching ship his mother. Over four decades, the second person of the hunt has become the first person of kinship. Chapter Nine draws the theoretical consequence.

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IX

Chapter Nine

Cynegetic Deixis

9.1 The Constellation of the Turn
9.2 The Four Turns
9.3 Person as Position: The Linguistics of the Hunt
9.4 You, It, I: The Grammar of the Dialectic
9.5 Venatic Personhood and the Question of Dignity
9.6 The Ethics of the Counter-Hunt
9.7 The Thermotropic Sovereign: The Demon of the Hottest Years
9.8 Objections and Limits
9.9 The Thesis Stated

The preceding chapters converge on a single proposition. In the world of the *Predator* franchise, personhood is neither a species property nor a rational endowment but a *position within the predatory relation*, conferred upon whoever can return the hunter's gaze, bleed and make bleed, and turn. I call this proposition **cynegetic deixis**. This chapter states it formally, grounds it in the linguistics of person and the anthropology of perspective, organizes the franchise's operations by the four turns of *trepein*, draws the ethical and planetary consequences, and confronts the objections it must answer.

9.1 The Constellation of the Turn

The franchise's recurrent elements resolve into a single semantic family. The Greek verb *trepein*, "to turn," generates the rout, the trophy, the solstice and the tropics, the figure of speech, the averting of evil, the organism's turning toward a stimulus, and, by a nineteenth-century coinage, entropy. One near-homophone stands outside the family, and its exclusion is the point.

Term	Greek	Gloss	Franchise operation	Chapters
tropē	τροπή	Turn; the rout of an enemy; turning point	The moment the hunted turns: Dutch's counterweight, Harrigan's disc, Naru's returned shot	2, 3
tropaion	τρόπαιον	Trophy raised where the enemy turned	Flayed bodies in the trees; skulls; the token of passage	4
tropai ēelioio; *tropikos*	τροπαὶ ἠελίοιο; τροπικός	Turnings of the sun; solstices; the tropics	The hunter of the hottest years, in jungles and heat waves	1, 6
apotropaios	ἀποτρόπαιος	Averting; turning evil away	The self-destruct; the trophy head as *gorgoneion*	4, 6
tropos	τρόπος	Manner; turn of phrase; trope	The migration of point of view; the franchise's figures	8, 9
-tropism	modern, from *tropē*	An organism's turning toward a stimulus	Thermotropism: the hunter turns toward heat	2, 9
entropy	Clausius (1865), from *tropē*	"Transformation" of heat	Bare heat; the mud as thermal death mask; the fireball	2
trophē (outside the family)	τροφή, from τρέφειν	Nourishment	The order the franchise refuses: the hunter never eats	4

The constellation organizes into four turns, each of which names one dimension of the franchise and one stage of its argument.

9.2 The Four Turns

The thermal turn. The hunter arrives at the turning of the sun, in the hottest season, and turns toward heat as a plant turns toward light. It perceives life as thermodynamic disequilibrium and reduces every being to bare heat; the prey survives by simulating entropy, approaching the thermal condition of the dead; the defeated hunter returns itself to heat in a solar fireball. The thermal turn is the franchise's physics and its ontology.

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The narrative turn. Every installment is organized around a *tropē*: the moment at which the hunted turns upon the hunter. Aristotle's *peripeteia* is its dramatic form, and Detienne and Vernant's *mētis* is its intelligence. The turn is always achieved by reversal, never by superior force: the hunter's mass becomes the counterweight, its disc becomes the weapon, its mask aims its own projectile. The narrative turn is the franchise's ethics of the weak.

The material turn. What the hunt produces is a *tropaion*, and the trophy itself turns. In the first phase it is a commemorative relic, denied to the victor by the hunter's expenditure; in the second it becomes a specimen, captured by laboratory, museum, and market; in the third it becomes a token of passage that admits its bearer to kinship. Its apotropaic double, the *gorgoneion* and the self-destruct, turns evil away for a season. The material turn is the franchise's economics.

The perspectival turn. The franchise's point of view migrates across four decades from the prey to the hunter, and the migration is figural as well as optical. Hayden White's *Metahistory* (1973), following Vico and Kenneth Burke, distinguished four master tropes by which narratives prefigure their material. They may serve here as a heuristic, not a law. The first phase is *metaphorical*: its hunter stands for something else, for Vietnam, for the Reaganite body, for colonial violence returned. The second is *metonymic*: it reduces the hunter and its prey to parts, whether weapons, corpses, genomes, or regenerative tissue, and treats the part as the thing. The third is *synecdochic*: its marks and tokens integrate the part into a whole, as the saliva-mark makes Dek a member of the Kalisk's family and the trophy head makes Naru a member of her people's history. Running through all three is White's fourth trope, *irony*, which in the franchise takes the form of its knowing self-reference, from the 2018 film's joke about the creature's name to the extended cut that stores the franchise's heroes in a vault for future use. The perspectival turn is the franchise's poetics, and it carries the theory of personhood that the dissertation proposes.

9.3 Person as Position: The Linguistics of the Hunt

Émile Benveniste's essays on pronouns ("The Nature of Pronouns," 1956; "Subjectivity in Language," 1958) showed that "I" and "you" have no reference outside the act of discourse in which they are uttered. "I" is whoever says "I"; "you" is whoever is addressed. Person is a position within an exchange, and the third person, the one spoken *about*, Benveniste called the "non-person." Roman Jakobson's term for such words was *shifters*. The franchise's founding exchange is a lesson in shifters. When Dutch asks "What the hell are you?" and the dying hunter returns the sentence, the pronoun "you" shifts its referent with its speaker. Each party is, for an instant, the other's second person, and the exchange constitutes them as persons to each other.

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Eduardo Viveiros de Castro's "Cosmological Deixis and Amerindian Perspectivism" (1998) found the same structure at the scale of a cosmology. In the Amerindian worlds he reconstructs, the words usually translated as "human being" do not denote a natural species. They function less as nouns than as pronouns, marking the position of the subject: whoever occupies the point of view sees itself as human and sees others as animals, spirits, or prey. Humanity is the general condition of all beings and animality the particular, and personhood is a matter of position and context rather than essence. Eduardo Kohn's *How Forests Think* (2013) opens with a lesson in the practical consequences. His Runa hosts advised him to sleep face up in the forest, so that a prowling jaguar would recognize him as a being that could look back, a self, and leave him alone; sleeping face down, he would appear as *aycha*, meat.

The franchise's code is the exact counterpart of Kohn's jaguar, and the comparison isolates its novelty. The jaguar hunts what it perceives as an "it" and avoids what it perceives as a "you": trophic predation requires the depersonalization of the prey. The Yautja hunt only what they perceive as a "you" and pass by what they perceive as an "it," the unarmed, the gravid, the bound: tropaic predation requires the *personalization* of the prey. The jaguar spares selves; the Yautja seek them. Both, however, tie personhood to the same capacity, the capacity to answer, and both confer it in the relation rather than in the species.

The franchise specifies that capacity under three heads, and they constitute the definition of cynegetic deixis. To be a person in the franchise's world is, first, to *return the gaze*: to see the hunter as the hunter sees, as Billy perceives the presence in the jungle, as Perseus's shield returns the Gorgon's look, and as Naru studies the creature until she knows how its mask aims. It is, second, to *bleed and make bleed*: to share the Hobbesian equality of killability that Dutch

formulates when he sees the creature's blood. It is, third, to *turn*: to perform the reversal of *mētis* upon a superior force. Whoever can do all three is a "you" to the hunter, and whoever can do none of them is passed by as an "it." The definition is indifferent to species. It is satisfied in turn by a commando, a detective, a guide, a Comanche healer, a Viking, a shinobi, a mechanic, and a Yautja runt.

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9.4 You, It, I: The Grammar of the Dialectic

The franchise's three phases can now be read as a sequence of grammatical persons. In the first phase the relation is in the second person. Hunter and prey address each other as "you"; their personhood is agonal, conferred in combat and confirmed by the gift. In the second phase the relation is in the third person. The apparatus of capture speaks only of "it": the expendable asset, the specimen, the acquisition, the genome, the regenerative resource. Its champion in 2018 cuts off the deictic question before the other can answer, because an apparatus cannot hear a "you." It converts the persons of the hunt into Benveniste's non-persons. In the third phase the relation is in the first person. The hunter speaks its own language, devised for *Badlands* by the linguist Britton Watkins[14], and the decisive words are possessive: Dek's own clan, Dek's mother[14].

The possessive pronoun is the grammar of kinship, and kinship terms are themselves shifters: my mother is someone else's daughter. Carlos Fausto's "Of Enemies and Pets" (1999) and "Feasting on People" (2007) describe Amazonian sociality as a process in which predation is converted into the production of kin. The captor familiarizes the captive, the enemy's child is raised as one's own, and the relation of hunter and prey becomes a relation of master and ward, of protector and protected. The franchise's third phase is a fiction of familiarizing predation. The jaguar's "you" and the Yautja's "you" both end, at last, in "my." Cynegetic deixis therefore has a terminus that the franchise reaches only in its last films. The position of the prey, once recognized, can be converted into the position of kin. I call that terminal position **familial deixis**, the moment at which the second person of the hunt becomes the first-person plural of the clan.

9.5 Venatic Personhood and the Question of Dignity

The modern Western theory of personhood, in its most influential form, is Kant's. The *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785) distinguishes what has a price, which can be replaced by an equivalent, from what has dignity (*Würde*), an inner worth beyond all price, and grounds dignity in rational autonomy. Dignity in this sense is intrinsic, universal, and unconditional. The personhood the franchise depicts is none of these. It is relational, conferred in an encounter; conditional, earned by the capacities to gaze, bleed, and turn; and revocable, lost when those capacities are lost. Call it *venatic personhood*. Its scandal is that it makes the defenseless invisible, as the hunter passes over the unarmed. Its insight is that the Kantian person was always defined against the animal, so that the human's exemption from the food chain, which Val Plumwood denounced, was the silent premise of human dignity.

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The franchise neither endorses venatic personhood nor dismisses it. It stages its dialectical correction. The first phase displays its glory and its cruelty. The second shows what happens when the institutions that claim to protect Kantian dignity treat persons as price, as when the CIA names a soldier an expendable asset, the state converts a town into a nuclear target, and the corporation treats a synthetic as a disposable tool. The third proposes a personhood that is relational like the hunter's and protective like Kant's, a personhood of kin. The alpha who protects the pack, the hunter spared because a child of the prey has marked him, and the healer whose knowledge of plants defeats a technology from the stars belong to an ethic that cannot be reduced to either dignity or the code.

9.6 The Ethics of the Counter-Hunt

The franchise's protagonists practice a consistent ethics, which can be stated in three imperatives. The first is *disappear*: subtract your signature from the sovereign gaze, as Dutch does with mud and Naru with herbs, rather than meet force with force. The second is *turn*: convert the superior power into the instrument of its own defeat. The third, which emerges only in the third phase, is *recognize without capturing*. The code recognizes the prey by hunting it, and the apparatus captures without recognizing. The counter-hunt ends in a recognition that neither kills nor appropriates. The three warriors of *Killer of Killers* recognize one another without a common language and refuse to become instruments of their captor. Dek frees the Kalisk from the corporation instead of taking its head. Each refuses the two available relations, the trophy and the specimen, for a third, alliance.

The ethic has a classical precedent in the hunting mythology reviewed in Chapter Six, from the twins of the Popol Vuh to Odysseus's Nobody. Its modern pertinence lies elsewhere. It answers the question that the apparatus of capture poses to every living being in an age of total extraction: how to be seen without being seized.

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9.7 The Thermotropic Sovereign: The Demon of the Hottest Years

The franchise's thermal allegory acquires its full meaning in the Anthropocene. Dipesh Chakrabarty's "The Climate of History: Four Theses" (2009) argued that humanity has become a geological agent and that the distinction between natural and human history has collapsed. In the franchise's terms, the human species has made itself maximally visible to a thermal gaze. Its cities, engines, and warming planet are its heat signature written at planetary scale. The hunter of the hottest years arrives in the season of the species' own making, and *The Predator* (2018) made the connection explicit when it attributed the hunters' renewed interest to humanity's approaching extinction by climate change[7].

The deeper identification has been prepared by the dissertation's argument. Chapter Three found that the Yautja code reproduces the selective ecology of the human trophy hunter, the "super predator" that takes the strongest adults of other species. Chapter Five found that the armed drone that borrowed the creature's name kills by thermal signature without risk or face. Chapter Four found that the trophy the creature hangs in the trees belongs to the archive of human violence. The **thermotropic sovereign**, the being that turns toward heat, kills for display, and treats the planet as its preserve, is a figure of the species that made the hottest years. The demon of the Anthropocene is the *Anthropos*, encountered from outside. The franchise's founding question therefore turns once more upon its asker. "What the hell are you?" is the question the planet's prey might put to the species that hunts them all, and the franchise's answer, delivered in its third phase, is that the hunter can still choose to become kin.

9.8 Objections and Limits

The thesis must answer seven objections.

The aestheticization of honorable violence. Susan Sontag's "Fascinating Fascism" (1975) warned against the aesthetic that glorifies strength, submission, and the warrior's beautiful death, and the Yautja code, with its cult of the worthy kill, is exposed to the charge. The franchise's own dialectic answers it in part. The code is shown to be cruel inward as well as outward, to culling its own weak

(Chapter Three), and it is superseded by an ethic of protection. The first phase's glamour, however, remains part of the franchise's appeal and of its commercial value, and the critique cannot be wholly discharged.

Racialized design. The creature's dreadlocks, its "tribal" ornament, and *Predator 2*'s urban setting drew Ebert's charge of racial coding[2], and the franchise's image of the alien as savage warrior belongs to the long history of the Wild Man. The development of Yautja culture and language in *Badlands* complicates the image but does not efface its inheritance.

Masculinism. The franchise began as a celebration and dismantling of hard male bodies, and its code is coded masculine. The evolution of its surviving women, from Anna to Naru, Ursa, and Thia, and the arrival of a Yautja mother at the end of *Badlands*, revise but do not overturn its gendered default.

The appropriation of Indigeneity. The franchise moved from the trope of the mystical native tracker to a Comanche protagonist and a Comanche-language dub, but its Indigenous stories have been directed and written by non-Native filmmakers. Raheja's visual sovereignty is approached, not achieved.

Pseudo-archaeology. AVP's ancient-astronaut mythology denied human cultures the authorship of their monuments (Chapter Six). The later films correct it, but the error remains in the corpus.

Disability as superpower. The Predator's framing of autism as the next stage of human evolution reproduces the "supercrip" narrative (Chapter Eight) and converts neurological difference into a resource for capture.

Franchise logic. Henry Jenkins's *Convergence Culture* (2006) and Derek Johnson's *Media Franchising* (2013) describe the industrial practices by which corporations multiply a property across media and creative workers. The dialectic traced here may be an effect of those practices: the crossover as asset management, the streaming prequel, the PG-13 rating, the vault of stored heroes in *Killer of Killers*' extended cut[12]. Roland Barthes warned in *Mythologies* (1957) that modern myth turns history into nature. The objection is valid, and it does not refute the thesis. Lévi-Strauss held that myths are anonymous and collective, and a franchise is the industrial form of anonymous collective authorship. That the system is commercial does not prevent it from thinking. It determines the conditions under which it thinks.

A last objection is the critic's: that a humanized Predator, as Peter Bradshaw put it, ceases to be the Predator[14]. The objection is correct, and cynegetic deixis predicts it. If personhood in the franchise is a position and not a species, then "the Predator" was never a kind of being. It was a role in a relation, and roles can be vacated. *Badlands* does not betray the franchise by humanizing its

monster. It completes the franchise's argument by showing that the position of the predator can be refused, by a member of the very species that defined it.

9.9 The Thesis Stated

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The *Predator* franchise is a tropaic machine. Its hunter arrives at the turning of the sun, perceives life as heat, and kills not to eat but to keep. Its code is a grammar of eligibility that confers personhood upon whoever can return the gaze, bleed and make bleed, and turn. Its narratives are organized around the turn of the hunted, its economy around the turning of the trophy, and its poetics around the migration of the point of view. Its antagonist is the apparatus that converts persons into resources. Across four decades it moves from predation as disqualification, through predation as capture, to predation as the ground of kinship, and the grammar of its founding question moves with it, from the second person of combat through the third person of capture to the first person of the clan. In an age when the human species has become the planet's super predator and the author of its hottest years, the franchise offers a modern myth in which humanity remembers that it was prey, meets its own predatory image in the hunter, and imagines that the hunter might become kin.



Conclusion

After the Hunt

Early in *Predator*, told by a comrade that he is bleeding, the gunner Blain answers, "I ain't got time to bleed." The line is the credo of the hard body: the refusal of vulnerability as the condition of strength. Blain is dead within the day[1]. The film's answer comes later, from Dutch, when he sees the creature's blood on the leaves: if it bleeds, it can be killed. Between the two sentences lies the franchise's argument. The first denies that the warrior bleeds; the second discovers that bleeding is shared, and that equality, recognition, and finally kinship rest on the common capacity to be wounded. This dissertation can be read as a commentary on the passage from Blain's line to Dutch's. The franchise teaches the human to make time to bleed.

The argument has advanced nine claims. The Predator's infrared sensorium constitutes a *thermal gaze* that reduces every being to *bare heat*, a thermographic analogue of bare life and an anticipation of the thermopolitics of signature strikes, border sensors, and fever screens (Chapter Two). The Yautja code is a *grammar of eligibility* whose mercy is disqualification and whose proper object is the *justa praeda*, the lawful prey (Chapter Three). The franchise invents *tropaic predation*, killing for display rather than nourishment, and its trophy follows a career from commemorative relic to captured specimen to token of kinship (Chapter Four). The true antagonist of every installment is an *apparatus of capture* that converts persons and hunts into resources, from the CIA's expendable assets to the corporation's regenerative harvest and the drone that borrowed the monster's name (Chapter Five). The hunter condenses the hunting mythologies of four continents, and the franchise's systematic transformation of them gives the heroic function to the prey (Chapter Six). Its horror is *elective horror*, the dread of being chosen and valued, the antithesis of Lovecraft's cosmic indifference (Chapter Seven). Across four decades it unfolds as a dialectic of disqualification, capture, and kinship (Chapter Eight). Its theory of the person is *cynegetic deixis*, personhood as a position conferred upon whoever can return the gaze, bleed and make bleed, and turn, which culminates in *familial deixis*, the conversion of the hunt's second person into the first person of the clan (Chapter Nine). And its hunter is a *thermotropic sovereign*, the demon of the hottest years, in which the human species meets, from outside, the image of its own planetary predation (Chapter Nine).

What remains of the human after the hunt? The Introduction asked the question, and the corpus answers it in two figures who meet only in its last phase. The first is Naru, the healer who learns to hunt the hunter. She defeats the being that sees by heat with the knowledge of a plant that cools the body, turns its own targeting upon it, and returns to tell her people that it is time to move.

She is the remembered prey, the human who knows that she can be hunted and has made that knowledge into a discipline of attention. The second is Dek, the hunter who learns to protect. He was condemned by his own code as too weak to live, was spared by a monster because a child had marked him as kin, and returned to refuse his father's offer of belonging in favor of the family he had chosen. He is the predator who discovers that the position of the predator can be refused. Val Plumwood, surviving the crocodile, concluded that the human being is food, and that a culture which forgets this misunderstands its place in the world. The franchise draws the further conclusion that a being who remembers being prey can recognize others as hunted, and that the recognition need not end in a trophy.

The myth remains open. As of this writing, Dan Trachtenberg has said only that the franchise's next steps are still being worked out[17]; the vault of *Killer of Killers* holds its stored heroes against a future battle; and the last image of *Badlands* is a ship on the horizon. Lévi-Strauss observed in "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) that a myth grows in a spiral, variant after variant, until the intellectual impulse that produced it is exhausted. There is no sign that this impulse is exhausted. The contradiction the franchise works through, that the human is at once the planet's apex hunter and a body that can be hunted, has not been resolved in the world outside the cinema.

The first of this dissertation's epigraphs is Heraclitus's fragment on war, usually cited for its opening clause: war is the father of all and king of all. The fragment continues, and its continuation contains the thesis. War, Heraclitus says, *showed* some to be gods and others humans, and *made* some slaves and others free. The verb translated "showed," *edeixe*, is the root of *deixis*. War, in the oldest formulation of Western philosophy, is deictic: it points out what each being is. The *Predator* franchise is a forty-year commentary on that fragment, in which the hunt shows who is a person and who is game, who is a god and who a mortal, who is captured and who goes free. Its last films add something Heraclitus did not foresee. The father of all is killed in the end, by a child of another species, and the mother arrives. In 1987 a man and a monster asked each other "What the hell are you?" The franchise has spent four decades answering. Its last answer is that each may become the other's kin.

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Predator franchise; Yautja; cynegetics; cynegetic deixis; familial deixis; *trepein*; *tropaion*; tropaic predation; trophic and tropaic; thermal gaze; bare heat; thermopolitics; thermotropic sovereign; *justa praeda*; grammar of eligibility; agonal personhood; venatic personhood; recognition; struggle for prestige; bracketing of war; war convention; *mētis*; Outis gambit; mētic reversal; ventriloquial predation; sovereign expenditure; potlatch; apparatus of capture; war machine; standing-reserve; state of exception; game preserve; telluric partisan; Amerindian perspectivism; familiarizing predation; Man the Hunted; paleo-anamnesis; elective horror; art-horror; monstrous double; Final Girl; reverse colonization; manhunt film; Wild Hunt; Tezcatlipoca; Popol Vuh; *krypteia*; Indigenous futurisms; visual sovereignty; media franchising; Anthropocene.